



सोमलिङ्गं नटो दृष्ट्वा सर्वपापैः प्रमुच्यते।
लभते फलं मनोवाञ्छितं मृतः स्वर्गं समाश्रयेत्॥

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Key Activities

Kalash Yatra | Bhajan Sandhya | Chanting of the Omkar Mantra
Mantra Writing in the Somnath Booklet
Narration of Stories Associated with Somnath

Shri Somnath Temple Complex, Prabhas Patan | 8th –11th May 2026

“Somnath is that song of hope which teaches us that the power of creation is far greater than the power of destruction”

– Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi (Chairman, Shri Somnath Trust)



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DURING TRUMP'S FIRST VISIT, XI OFFERED A TOUR OF FORBIDDEN CITY

Iran war could make Trump’s China trip a bit chillier than earlier one

WASHINGTON: Weeks before his trip to China, President Donald Trump was already predicting on social media that his Chinese counterpart, Xi Jinping, would “give me a big, fat hug when I get there”. But Beijing’s deep economic ties to Iran, as well as trade tensions over tariff threats stretching back to Trump’s first term, could crimp the good feelings when Trump flies to Beijing this week — even though the Republican president has for years effusively praised Xi, making it clear he sees China’s leader as a competitor strong enough to warrant his respect and admiration.

Trump isn’t fond of long plane rides or extended stretches away from the White House or his properties in Florida and New Jersey. He is expected to only spend parts of three days on the ground in China. There will be plenty



US President Donald Trump

of pomp, but the grandeur is not expected to rival Trump’s first visit to China in 2017, which Beijing dubbed a “state visit-plus”.

“Even before this whole conflagration with Iran, they weren’t going to go state visit-plus like last time, just because things are tense,” said Jona-

than Czin, a former director for China at the National Security Council during the Biden administration.

On Trump’s first-term trip, China rolled out the red carpet for his arrival, with a band playing military music and children waving flags and chanting “Welcome.” Xi offered

Highlights

- » Trump isn’t fond of long plane rides or extended stretches away from the White House
- » On Trump’s first-term trip, China rolled out the red carpet for his arrival
- » There will be plenty of pomp, but the grandeur is not expected to rival Trump’s first visit to China in 2017

a tour of the Forbidden City. Trump and first lady Melania Trump even had a private dinner there. Trump was the first foreign leader since the People’s Republic of China was founded in 1949 to experience what was once reserved for emperors.

The following morning brought another welcome cer-

emony at the Great Hall of the People and featured a military parade. There also was a state banquet in Trump’s honour with video highlights from the Chinese leader’s previous visit to Florida and a clip of Trump’s granddaughter Arabella singing in Chinese.

Beijing does not offer this level of spectacle to most visiting foreign leaders. When British Prime Minister Keir Starmer visited the Forbidden City in January, Xi did not attend and the site remained open to the public. Starmer had to contend with tourists.

Ali Wyne, senior US-China research and advocacy adviser for the Washington nonprofit the Crisis Group, said the “Chinese delegation will likely do its utmost to ensure that Trump leaves Beijing believing that he has just concluded the most extraordinary state visit of his two presidencies.” AGENCIES

Israeli strikes kill three people in Gaza, medics say, testing ceasefire

CAIRO/GAZA: Israeli strikes killed at least three Palestinians in Gaza on Sunday, including two members of the Hamas-run police force, health officials said, in violence that underscored the fragility of a U.S.-brokered ceasefire.

Medics said an Israeli airstrike killed one person and wounded two others in the Maghazi refugee camp in central Gaza.

The Israeli military said it struck two militants who were carrying out “suspicious” activity and approached forces in the area, posing an immediate threat.

Separately on Sunday, an Israeli airstrike killed the head of the criminal police force in Khan Younis, Wessam Abdel-Hadi, and his aide, according to Gaza’s Hamas-run interior ministry.

The Israeli military said it struck militants of the elite Hamas force in the southern Gaza Strip which operated to “advance imminent attacks” against Israeli forces.

Reuters has previously reported that Israel has inten-



Representational Image

sified its attacks on Gaza’s Hamas-run police force, which the militant group has used to re-establish governance in areas under its control.

Violence in Gaza has persisted despite an October 2025 ceasefire, with Israel conducting almost daily attacks.

At least 850 Palestinians have been killed since the ceasefire took effect, local medics say, while Israel says militants have killed four of its soldiers over the same period.

Israel and Hamas have

blamed each other for ceasefire violations.

The blast that killed the two police officers left only a mangled metal skeleton where their car had stood in the Al-Amal neighbourhood of Khan Younis in southern Gaza.

Mourners chanted “there is no God but Allah, the martyrs are beloved by Allah” as the men’s white-shrouded bodies were carried on shoulders through the streets during the funeral. AGENCIES

Russia accuses Ukraine of violating 3-day truce



REPRESENTATIONAL IMAGE

MOSCOW: Russia accused Kyiv of breaking a US-brokered ceasefire on Sunday, while Ukrainian officials said that one person had been killed and more injured by Russian drone and artillery strikes in the past 24 hours.

Two people were injured by Ukrainian shelling in the Russian-occupied part of Ukraine’s Kherson region, the area’s Moscow-installed leader, Vladimir Saldo, said. Separately, Russia’s Ministry of Defence accused Kyiv of committing more than 1,000 ceasefire violations, state media reported, citing a daily briefing on Sunday. The ministry said Ukrainian forces had attacked civilian targets in several Russian regions and carried out strikes against Russian military positions on the frontline.

Russia’s military “responded in kind” to the ceasefire violations, the ministry said. Ukrainian officials said Russia had launched attacks, although they stopped short of accusing Moscow of violating the US-brokered truce that came into force on Saturday.

Ivan Fedorov, head of Ukraine’s southeastern Zaporizhzhia region, said one person had been killed and three more

Ukrainian officials said Russia had launched attacks, although they stopped short of accusing Moscow of violating truce that came into force on Saturday

injured by artillery and drone attacks in the past 24 hours.

Oleksandr Prokudin, the head of Ukraine’s Kherson, said that seven people had been wounded over the same period.

Five people were also injured when a Russian drone attack damaged a nine-storey apartment block in the industrial district of Ukraine’s second-largest city, Oleh Syniehubov, the head of the Kharkiv regional administration, said late Saturday. US President Donald Trump said Friday that Russia and Ukraine had bowed to his request for a ceasefire running Saturday through Monday to mark Victory Day, the Russian celebration marking the defeat of Nazi Germany. AGENCIES

Plane carrying Spanish passengers from hantavirus-hit cruise ship leaves for Madrid

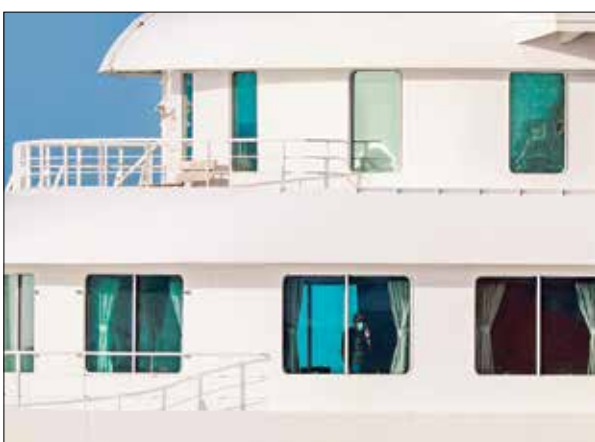
TENERIFE: The first plane carrying passengers from the hantavirus-hit cruise ship left Spain’s Canary Islands on Sunday for Madrid, where they will be taken to a military hospital.

Spanish nationals were the first to leave the MV Hondius, which remains anchored off Tenerife, the largest island in the Spanish archipelago off West Africa’s coast. The ship arrived hours earlier.

None of the more than 140 people on the Hondius has shown symptoms of the virus, Spain’s health ministry, the World Health Organization and cruise company Oceanwide Expeditions said.

WHO Director-General Tedros Adhanom Ghebreyesus sought to reassure the public, repeating on Sunday that the risk for the general public from the outbreak remained low.

Even so, those disembarking and personnel working at the port of Granadilla in Tenerife wore protective gear during



REPRESENTATIONAL IMAGE

the evacuation process, including face masks, hazmat suits and respirators.

Spanish Health Minister Mónica García said that the operation was proceeding normally.

Passengers and some crew members from more than 20 nationalities on board will be

evacuated throughout Sunday into Monday.

After reaching Madrid, those evacuated on the first plane will be under quarantine, Spanish health authorities said. Only the 14 Spanish nationals on board will quarantine in the country.

Authorities have said the

Know More

- » Spanish nationals were the first to leave the MV Hondius
- » The cruise ship reached Tenerife early Sunday morning, after leaving Cape Verde on May 6
- » Three people have died since the outbreak, and five passengers who left the ship are infected with hantavirus

passengers and crew members disembarking will be checked for symptoms, have no contact with the local population and will only be taken off the ship once evacuation flights are ready to fly them to their destinations. Tedros and Spain’s health and interior ministers are supervising the operation in Tenerife. AGENCIES

Pak: 15 security officials killed in militant attack

PESHAWAR: At least 15 security officials were killed and several were injured in a suicide attack and ambush at a police post in Pakistan’s restive Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province, the police said.

The incident took place on Saturday in the northwest district of Bannu where an explosive-laden vehicle approaching a police post was fired at by security personnel, leading to a blast, the police said.

The impact of the explosion led to the collapse of the roofs of several houses in the vicinity. The police post building was also razed to the ground, and several security personnel were buried under the rubble.

After the explosion, the police said, a large group of militants launched an attack on the police post, triggering heavy exchange of fire.

A spokesperson of Bannu police told PTI that 15 security officials were killed in the attack and several were injured.

“THE IMPACT OF THE EXPLOSION LED TO THE COLLAPSE OF THE ROOFS OF SEVERAL HOUSES IN THE VICINITY”

There is no clarity yet on the number of militants killed in the incident or whether any of them were held.

Khyber Pakhtunkhwa Chief Minister Muhammad Sohail Afridi condemned the “terrorist attack” and expressed sorrow over the loss of lives. His office said he has directed the authorities to ensure the best possible medical treatment for the injured.

He termed the attack on the police post as “highly tragic and a cowardly act,” adding that such attacks could not undermine the morale of the police and the public. AGENCIES

Ship caught fire after being hit off coast of Qatar: British military

DUBAI: The British military said a ship caught fire Sunday after being hit by an unknown projectile off the coast of Qatar.

The United Kingdom Maritime Trade Operations Centre said the attack caused a small fire on the bulk carrier, which was extinguished. The attack happened 23 nautical miles (43 km) northeast of Qatar’s capital, Doha, the UKMTO said.

There were no reported casualties, it said.

It was the latest attack on vessels in the Persian Gulf since a shaky ceasefire stopped fighting between the United States and Iran. There have been several attacks against ships in the Persian Gulf over the past week. On Friday, the US struck two Iranian oil tankers after it said the tankers were trying to breach its blockade of Iran’s ports. Iran’s Revolutionary Guard navy has warned that any attack on Iranian oil tankers or commercial vessels would be met with a “heavy assault” on one of the US bases in the region and enemy ships. AGENCIES

Former UK minister challenges PM’s leadership

The Labour MP from north London on Saturday launched a ‘stalking horse’ leadership

LONDON: Catherine West, a former Indo-Pacific minister in British Prime Minister Keir Starmer’s government, has given Labour ministers an ultimatum to unite behind a successor after the party’s disastrous local election results.

The Labour MP from north London on Saturday launched a ‘stalking horse’ leadership bid aimed at encouraging a stronger contender to emerge.

West said that Labour’s poor performance in Thursday’s elections for local councils across England and devolved administrations in Wales and Scotland was a “message from the working people” and the party must act to keep Reform UK leader Nigel Farage out of Downing Street.

“I was honoured to serve under Keir Starmer’s leadership, both in Opposition and in Government. All of us in the Labour Party are thankful to Keir for the 2024 General Election and the good work since. I personally get on well with Keir,” said West.

“But his approach is not cutting through, and the results over the past 48 hours are nothing short of disastrous. Unless



UK PM Keir Starmer

things change, we risk Nigel Farage becoming prime minister. That’s why, with regret and significant sadness, I firmly believe that Keir should outline his intention to resign as Prime Minister and oversee an orderly transition.

“The Labour Party need the chance to have an honest conversation about how we

deliver the change we promised in 2024, and that requires new leadership which understands the urgent and real concerns of people across the UK,” she said.

Starmer has indicated plans for a major speech on Monday to set out his strategy to revive the Labour government’s electoral fortunes before a general election in 2029, starting

Starmer has indicated plans for a major speech on Monday to set out his strategy to revive the Labour government’s electoral fortunes before a general election in 2029

with the appointment of former Prime Minister Gordon Brown as advisor.

However, West has demanded that Starmer must use the speech to set out a timetable for his exit as party leader to make way for a new PM.

“Keir has demonstrated significant leadership on the world stage and is well placed to represent the UK’s national interest while this process takes place and may even continue in an international role in the future but for now I know I speak for more Labour people than just myself in wanting him to step aside

as our Leader,” she added in a social media post.

Speaking to reporters on Sunday, the former Foreign Office minister said that she will be forced to enter the race to trigger a leadership election unless ministers choose a credible successor.

“Once I’ve listened carefully to what he (Starmer) says (on Monday), I will be demanding a timetable for an orderly transition,” West told reporters.

“What I want the Cabinet to do is to close themselves into a room today and come up with somebody who they can all get behind, which would mean we wouldn’t have to have a leadership election,” the Labour MP said.

“And if that can happen, then we can have a very quiet transition without upsetting anybody, without having to go to all of the members,” she added.

Starmer has pledged to fight on despite the Labour’s historic defeat, losing swathes of council seats across England to smaller parties led by anti-immigration Reform UK, with Greens and Liberal Democrats also picking up key councils. AGENCIES

World Briefs

BODIES OF 3 HIKERS RETRIEVED FROM INDONESIAN VOLCANO AFTER ERUPTION

JAKARTA: Rescuers on Indonesia’s remote island of Halmahera found the bodies of two Singaporean hikers on Sunday, two days after they were caught in a volcanic eruption on Mount Dukono, officials said. The bodies of the men, aged 30 and 27, were located a few metres from where the first victim, an Indonesian female hiker, was found dead on Saturday, Abdul Muhari, the National Disaster Management Agency’s spokesperson, said. All three had been about 50 metres (165 feet) from the rim of the main crater. The men’s bodies were covered by thick layers of volcanic material, Muhari said, adding that the densely packed material had complicated evacuation efforts and significantly slowed progress.

BANGLADESH’S HC REJECTS DETAINED HINDU MONK’S BAIL PETITION

DHAKA: Bangladesh’s High Court on Sunday rejected a bail petition of Hindu monk Brahmachari Chinmoy Krishna Das since he is being tried in a lower court in connection with a lawyer’s murder in 2024. Das, a spokesperson for the Bangladesh Sammilita Sanatani Jagran Jote, was arrested from Dhaka’s Hazrat Shahjalal International Airport on November 25, 2024 for alleged sedition. He was jailed after he was denied bail by a court in the southeastern port city of Chattogram, which prompted his followers to protest in Dhaka and other places the next day.



CITY: Pg 5

Delhi govt announces Rs 3.5 cr aftercare scheme for children leaving care homes



NATION: Pg 9

UT with dual power structure 'worst form of govt', says Omar Abdullah



FILM: Pg 12

'Actors take the bigger cut'

PM calls for reduced petrol, diesel consumption amid West Asia crisis

Urges for resolutions by people to save foreign exchange to overcome impact of war

OUR CORRESPONDENT

HYDERABAD: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday urged citizens to adopt restraint in fuel consumption and make lifestyle adjustments to help India navigate the economic strain caused by the ongoing West Asia conflict, while also unveiling development projects worth about Rs 9,400 crore in Telangana. Addressing a public gathering and an official event in Hyderabad, the Prime Minister linked global disruptions in energy and supply chains to rising domestic costs, calling for collective efforts to reduce dependence on imports and conserve foreign exchange.

Speaking at the Hyderabad International Convention Centre, Modi said the effects of the war were being felt through higher prices of petrol and fertilisers, as well as pressure on supply chains. "When there is pressure on the supply chain, difficulties increase despite various measures by the government to overcome the crisis," he said, adding that the country must respond with "resolutions" that prioritise national interest during a global crisis.

He called on citizens to use petrol, diesel and gas only when necessary, stressing that restrained consumption would



Prime Minister Narendra Modi addresses a public meeting, at Secunderabad in Hyderabad, Telangana, Sunday

PROMOTES NATURAL FARMING AND SWADESHI PRODUCTS

not only help conserve foreign exchange but also reduce the indirect impact of geopolitical tensions. "Today, the need of the hour is to use petrol, gas, diesel and similar resources with restraint," he said. He also suggested practical steps such as greater use of metro rail services, car pooling, adoption of electric vehicles, and increased reliance on railways for transporting goods.

Recalling behavioural shifts during the COVID-19 pandemic, Modi urged people to revive practices like remote work, virtual meetings and video conferencing to cut fuel usage and save resources. He also asked citizens to postpone non-essential foreign travel and gold purchases for a year as part of broader efforts to conserve foreign exchange.

The Prime Minister fur-

ther appealed for reduced consumption of edible oil and chemical fertilisers, while encouraging natural farming and the use of domestically produced goods. These measures, he said, would contribute to self-reliance while easing pressure on imports.

Alongside the economic message, Modi highlighted India's progress in energy diversification. He said the country

HIGHLIGHTS

- » PM warns supply chain disruptions increasing economic pressure
- » Advises saving foreign exchange through lifestyle changes
- » Suggests carpooling, metro use, EV adoption, and rail transport
- » Recommends reviving work-from-home and virtual meetings
- » Urges postponing foreign travel and gold purchases for a year
- » Advocates reduced edible oil and chemical fertiliser use.

'New era starts now': Vijay takes oath as Tamil Nadu CM

Declares himself sole power centre in coalition government

MPOST BUREAU

CHENNAI: All eyes were on superstar-turned-politician C Joseph Vijay as he arrived for his historic oath-taking ceremony as Tamil Nadu Chief Minister, cheered by a sea of joyous supporters on Sunday. He began his innings with a pledge that "a new era of real, secular, social justice starts now."

His rise to power after his two-year-old party TVK emerged as the single largest party in the recent Assembly elections, marks a major political alignment in the state. His party's victory also smashed the decades-long dominance of the DMK and AIADMK in Tamil Nadu.

'Bussy' N Anand, Aadhav Arjuna and K A Sengottaiyan were also administered the oath of office of minister by Governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar at Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium here. The swearing-in ceremony was attended by senior leaders, including Leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi and family and friends of Vijay.

Others who took the oath as ministers in Vijay's cabinet included K G Arunraaj, P Venkataramanan, C T R Nirmal Kumar, A Rajmohan, Keerthana and K T Prabhu.

"It is a fresh, new beginning. A new era of real, sec-



Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) Chief C. Joseph Vijay speaks during the oath taking ceremony of Tamil Nadu CM, in Chennai on Sunday

KEY POINTS

- » Ministers sworn in include 'Bussy' N Anand, Aadhav Arjuna, K A Sengottaiyan
- » Cabinet also features K G Arunraaj, P Venkataramanan, Nirmal Kumar, Rajmohan, Keerthana, Prabhu
- » Rahul Gandhi attends ceremony with other senior leaders
- » Vijay signs three orders: 200 units free power, women's safety task force, anti-drug task force

ular, social justice starts..." Vijay paused, looked down, pointed at his wrist watch and added with a dramatic flourish: "Now!" This statement was greeted with thunderous applause, cheers and whistles.

He also signed three orders --200 units of free electricity, a task force for women's safety and a task force to tackle the drug menace.

Asserting that he was not from any royal lineage, Vijay, in an emotive speech in chaste Tamil, said people "welcomed and accepted" him, and he will never deceive them with false promises.

Accusing the previous DMK regime of 'burdening' the state with Rs 10 lakh crore debt, Vijay asked people to give him

Assam Guv appoints Himanta Sarma as CM, swearing in on May 12

MPOST BUREAU

GUWAHATI: Assam is set to see the continuation of the BJP-led National Democratic Alliance (NDA) government after Governor Lakshman Prasad Acharya on Sunday invited Chief Minister-elect Himanta Biswa Sarma to form the next administration. The development clears the way for the alliance's third consecutive term in the state.

Sarma, who was unanimously chosen as the leader of the NDA legislative party, met the governor at Lok Bhavan along with alliance partners to formally stake claim. A statement from Lok Bhavan confirmed the move, saying, "The governor has invited Dr Himanta Biswa Sarma to form the new government in Assam."

The swearing-in ceremony is scheduled for May 12 at the Veterinary College Playground in Khanapara. Several senior leaders are expected to attend, including Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Union Home Minister Amit Shah, Defence Minister Rajnath Singh and BJP president Nitin Nabin.

The NDA, comprising the Bharatiya Janata Party,



2 CABINET MINISTERS, 4 STATE MINISTERS INDUCTED

Yogi expands Cabinet as BJP pushes social engineering ahead of 2027 UP elections



Uttar Pradesh Governor Anandiben Patel, state Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath, state Deputy Chief Minister Keshav Prasad Maurya and Brajesh Pathak during the expansion event of the state government, in Lucknow, Sunday

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

LUCKNOW: In a major political exercise aimed at strengthening the Bharatiya Janata Party's caste and regional equations before the 2027 Uttar Pradesh Assembly elections, Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Sunday expanded his council of ministers by inducting six new faces and promoting two ministers.

Former state BJP chief Bhupendra Singh Chaudhary and Samajwadi Party rebel MLA Manoj Kumar Pandey were sworn in as Cabinet ministers during a ceremony at Raj Bhavan where Governor Anandiben Patel administered the oath of office and secrecy.

Ajit Pal Singh and Somendra Tomar, who were earlier ministers of state, were elevated as Ministers of State with independent charge. Kailash Rajput, Krishna Paswan, Surendra Diler and Hansraj Vishwakarma were inducted as ministers of state.

The Cabinet expansion is being seen as the BJP's attempt to recalibrate its social coalition after the setbacks it faced in Uttar Pradesh during the 2024 Lok Sabha elections. The party has focused on accommodating leaders from non-Yadav OBC and non-Jatav Dalit communities while also strengthening its hold in western Uttar Pradesh.

Continued on P6

Congress keeps Kerala CM choice in suspense

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Suspense continued over the choice of the next Kerala chief minister on Sunday as the party high command is yet to arrive at a decision.

Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge and former party chief Rahul Gandhi are seized of the matter and the name is likely to be announced soon, sources said.

Congress leader K Murali Natarajan said the party workers are bound to accept the high command's decision regarding

Continued on P6

Iran sends response to US ceasefire proposal as drones target Gulf nations

Tehran pushes for broader talks covering Lebanon front

ASSOCIATED PRESS

DUBAI: Iran has sent its response to the latest US ceasefire proposal via Pakistani mediators and wants negotiations to focus on permanently ending the war, Iran's state-run media said Sunday. Pakistan confirmed receiving it.

Iran seeks to end the war on all fronts, including in Lebanon, where Israel fights the Iranian-backed Hezbollah militant group, and to ensure the security of shipping, its state TV said.

Washington's latest proposal addressed a deal to end the war, reopen the Strait of Hormuz and roll back Iran's



nuclear program, an issue that Tehran would rather discuss later.

The White House had

no immediate comment about Iran's reply. President Donald Trump is giving diplomacy

Continued on P6



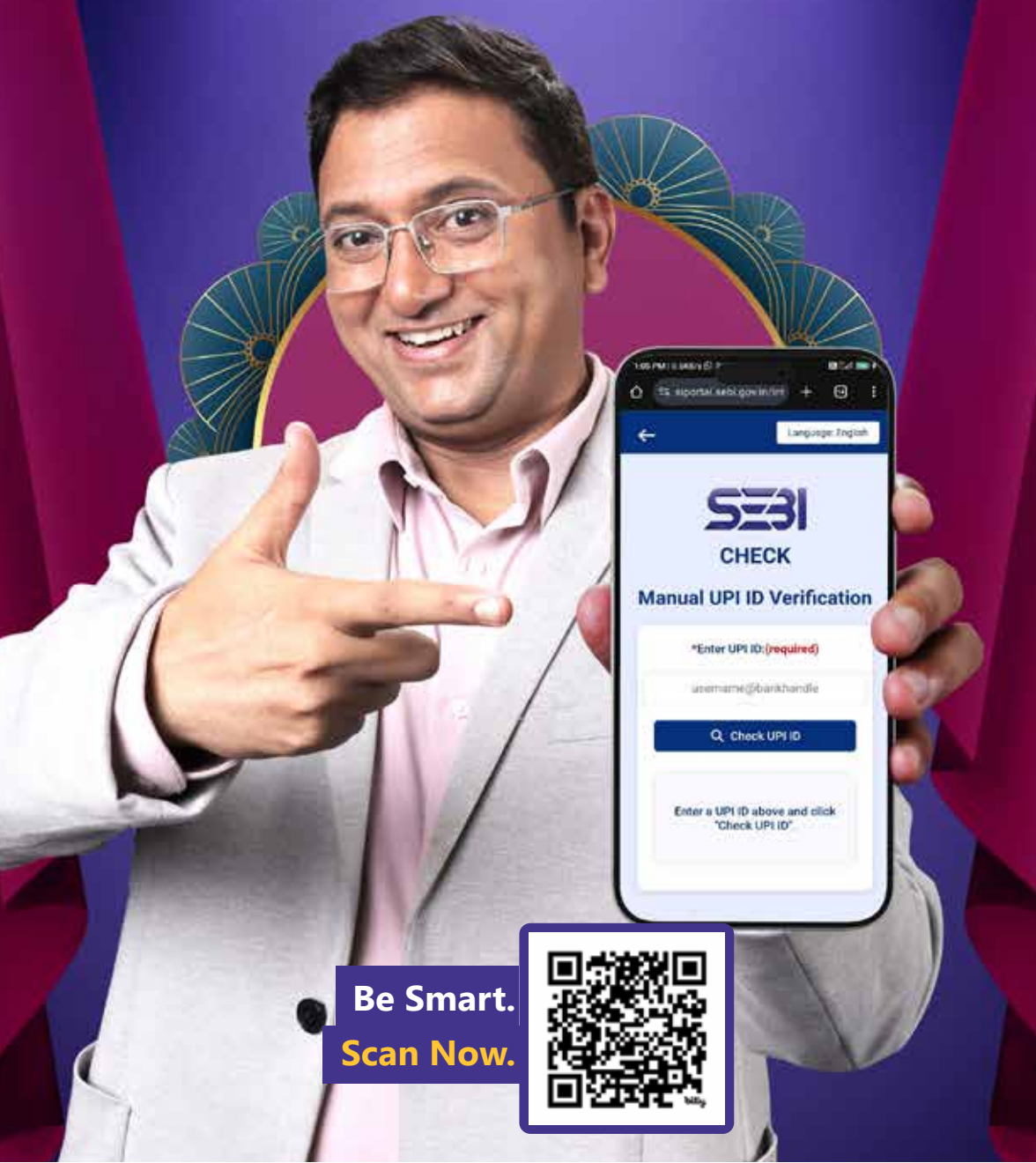
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POLICE RECOVER WEAPON USED IN MURDER

Teenager stabbed to death in New Usmanpur; juvenile apprehended

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A 15-year-old boy was stabbed to death allegedly by a juvenile following a dispute in northeast Delhi's New Usmanpur area, police said on Sunday.

The incident came to light on Saturday evening when police received information from the Jag Pravesh Chandra Hospital regarding the admission of a minor with stab injuries, they said.

The boy subsequently succumbed to his injuries.

According to the police, the boy was taken to the hospital by his family members after the attack.

Police identified the involvement of a 17-year-old boy in the case during interrogation, the officer said.

The juvenile was apprehended and, during question-



ing, stated that he had a dispute with the deceased, the officer added. At his instance, police recovered the knife allegedly used in the crime.

Police identified the deceased as Ayan Ansari, a resident of Gali Number Seven near Gaddhe Wali Masjid in Gautam Vihar, Brahmpuri. He was a Class 10 student and

lived with his parents and two younger brothers. His father runs a scrap shop, police said.

According to police, the accused juvenile and the victim were known to each other and had a long-standing dispute.

During the investigation, police found that on Saturday evening, the victim's younger brother, Sanib, was returning

KEY POINTS

- » The boy was taken to the hospital by his family members after the attack: Police officers
- » The boy subsequently succumbed to his injuries
- » Police identified the involvement of a 17-year-old boy in the case during interrogation, the officer said

home when he encountered the accused and his friends in the locality. The accused allegedly scolded and slapped him.

After learning about the incident, Ayan went to K Block, Gali Number Four, Gaddhe Wali Gali on a scooter along with a friend and questioned the accused and his associates over the matter, police said.

During the confrontation, the accused and his associates allegedly attacked Ayan with knives and stabbed him multiple times before fleeing the spot. Police said the victim sustained seven stab injuries.

Ayan was rushed to Jag Pravesh Chandra Hospital by his family members, where doctors declared him dead. His body was later sent to GTB Hospital for post-mortem examination.

A forensic team inspected the crime scene and collected evidence, police said. A team led by SHO Rajendra Kumar was formed to crack the case, and the juvenile accused was apprehended from the Third Pushta area on Sunday morning. Police said the accused works as a plumber. Efforts are underway to identify and trace the other persons allegedly involved in the attack.

Karol Bagh firing accused held after exchange of fire

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police has arrested two alleged shooters wanted in the recent Karol Bagh firing case following a brief exchange of fire near Zakir Hussain College in central Delhi late on Friday night.

The accused were identified as Deepanshu alias Sahil alias Bouncer (28), a resident of Faiz Road in Karol Bagh, and Avinash (24), a resident of the Tibbiya College area in Karol Bagh.

According to police, the arrests were made after the Special Staff of the Central district received a tip-off about the movement of the suspects, who had allegedly been absconding for several days. The two were reportedly linked to the firing case registered at Karol Bagh Police Station.

Police said the accused were intercepted near Pratibha Vidyalaya on Turkman Road in the Kamla Market area while allegedly on their way to target a member of a rival gang.

The operation was part of



an ongoing drive against gangsters, robbers and organised criminal elements active in Central and North Delhi districts. Several other accused in the same firing case, including Pankaj alias Mohit, Ajay alias Gunga, Montu and Aakash, had already been arrested earlier.

Officials said the Special Staff received specific information at around 8.50 pm on May 9 that the two suspects would be travelling on a brown Activa scooter from Gandhi Market towards Civic Centre carrying illegal firearms, allegedly with the intention of eliminating a shooter associated with the rival Rohit alias Mota gang.

Acting on the input, a raiding team led by Inspector Rohit

Kumar laid a trap near Turkman Road. At around 10.20 pm, the suspects arrived on the scooter and allegedly opened indiscriminate fire after spotting the police team. During the exchange, one bullet struck Inspector Rohit Kumar's bullet-proof jacket. Police retaliated in self-defence, injuring both accused in their legs before overpowering and apprehending them. The injured men were later shifted to LNJP Hospital under police supervision.

Police recovered a pistol with a magazine, a country-made katta, three live cartridges, ten empty cartridge cases and the scooter used in the incident. Investigation revealed that the scooter had been stolen from the Malviya Nagar area last year. A fresh case has been registered at Kamla Market Police Station under relevant sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and the Arms Act. Police said further investigation is underway to trace other gang members and examine possible links to organised criminal networks.

Street vendor held for supplying illegal firearms

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police Crime Branch has arrested a street vendor for allegedly possessing and supplying illegal firearms in the national capital following a late-night operation near Vegas Mall in Dwarka.

The accused, identified as Naveen alias Vivek (27), a resident of Sonia Vihar, was allegedly found in possession of a semi-automatic pistol and three live cartridges, police said. According to officials, the arrest was part of an ongoing crackdown on individuals displaying weapons on social media platforms. The investigation began after the Crime Branch received information that a juvenile from Tughlakabad Extension had uploaded photographs on social media while holding illegal pistols.

A Crime Branch team reached Govindpuri for verification and examined the juvenile's mobile phone, where photographs showing him with a firearm were recovered. During questioning, the juvenile allegedly disclosed that the weapon belonged to his acquaintance Kishan, a resident of Giri Nagar, and had been supplied by Naveen.

Police said the juvenile further revealed that Naveen operated a soya chaap stall named "The Chaap Delight" near Vegas Mall and was allegedly involved in supplying illegal firearms across Delhi.

Acting on the lead, a team led by Inspector Parvesh Lamba apprehended Naveen during the intervening night of May 8 and 9. During interrogation, he allegedly confessed to procuring weapons from Uttar Pradesh and supplying them across Delhi-NCR.

Police said Naveen is already involved in three criminal cases, including attempt to murder and Arms Act cases.

Two gardeners beaten to death at Gr Noida institute; colleague caught after encounter

DIPIKA KIROLA

GREATER NOIDA: Police have solved the sensational double murder of two gardeners at a private management institute in Greater Noida's Knowledge Park-3 within 24 hours, arresting a 24-year-old co-worker who allegedly killed the duo over a personal grudge linked to his deceased sister.

The accused, Abhishek Kumar, a resident of Meerut, was arrested following a brief police encounter near the Gurjarpur railway line under the Knowledge Park Police Station area. Police said a country-made pistol and live cartridges were recovered from his possession.

The victims, Sheeshpal and



Indra alias Dharmendra, both around 45 years old and residents of Meerut, were found dead inside an under-construction hostel building at the institute on Friday morning. Both had sustained multiple head and body injuries.

According to police, the three men had recently arrived in Greater Noida for gardening work at the institute. Suspicion fell on Abhishek after he

allegedly disappeared from the site before the bodies were discovered. "Given the suspicious circumstances, a case under Section 103(1) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita for murder was registered and investigation teams were formed," said Greater Noida DCP Dr Pravin Ranjan Singh.

During interrogation, Abhishek allegedly confessed to the crime and told investigators that he held a long-standing grudge against Sheeshpal over the latter's past relationship with his deceased sister. Police said the accused claimed both victims frequently mocked him over the issue.

Investigators said Abhishek had allegedly planned the murders before coming to Greater

Noida and deliberately joined the same workplace. On Thursday night, he allegedly made both men consume alcohol while remaining relatively sober himself.

After the victims fell asleep, Abhishek allegedly attacked Sheeshpal with a shovel, repeatedly striking him on the head and body. When Indra woke up during the assault, the accused allegedly attacked him as well, causing fatal injuries.

Police said the bodies were discovered on Friday morning, triggering an intensive probe that led to the accused's arrest within a day. Another case under BNS Section 109 and relevant provisions of the Arms Act was also registered against him following the encounter.

Bawana: Min inaugurates new DJB pipeline projects

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: In a push to strengthen civic infrastructure in outer Delhi, Cabinet Minister Ravinder Indraj Singh on Saturday inaugurated new Delhi Jal Board (DJB) pipeline projects at Village Jat Khor and Kali Mata Mandir in Prakash Vihar under the Bawana Assembly constituency.

The projects aim to provide residents with cleaner, uninterrupted and improved water supply facilities, particularly in unauthorised colonies and rural areas that have long faced infrastructure challenges.

According to officials, the initiative is part of a broader development drive in the region, which includes water pipeline expansion, road repairs, construction of footpaths, drainage systems and other civic amenities.

Addressing residents during the inauguration programme, Ravinder Indraj Singh said the government was focused on ensuring that development directly benefits people at the grassroots level.

'Roads, sewer systems and water pipelines, our goal is to rebuild every civic facility in a modern manner': Min

"Development is not measured merely by announcements, but by facilities reaching people's homes," the minister said. He added that the Delhi government's priority was to provide clean water, improved sewer systems and modern civic infrastructure to every citizen.

Highlighting the government's long-term vision, he said, "Roads, sewer systems and water pipelines, our goal is to rebuild every civic facility in a modern and efficient manner. We remain fully committed to public service and the continuous development of the region."

The minister stated that the projects align with the vision of Prime Minister Narendra Modi for integrated urban development and Chief Minister Rekha Gupta's commitment to improving basic amenities across Delhi.

Ggm Police arrest realtor for Rs 17 crore land fraud

OUR CORRESPONDENT

GURUGRAM: Gurugram Police has arrested a 50-year-old owner of a real estate firm for allegedly duping people of crores by promising land agreements, officials said on Sunday.

The accused has been identified as Mahesh Mugam, a resident of Sector 75, Noida, they said.

According to the police, on January 20, a man filed a complaint stating that Neon Infra Construction Solutions Company and its affiliates had shown him documents promising to sell approximately 11.33 acres of land in Ghughera village in Palwal district of Haryana.

The accused executed an agreement to sell the land on August 1, 2024, and received approximately Rs 17 crore for the total price and other expenses.

The complainant added that the accused failed to register the land and cut off contact.

A case was registered at Sector 40 police station. A police team from the Economic Offences Wing-1 investigated



CLOSER LOOK

- » The accused executed an agreement to sell the land on Aug 1, 2024, and received approximately Rs 17 cr for total price
- » The complainant added that the accused failed to register the land and cut off contact: Cops

the matter and arrested the accused on Saturday, the officials said.

Further investigation is underway, the police said.

Vivek Vihar: Fire breaks out in electricity meter control box; no injuries

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A fire broke out in an electricity meter control box on the ground floor of a residential building in Vivek Vihar Phase-I in east Delhi on Sunday, officials said.

Nothing to fear, as it was a small fire in the MC box, the officials said, adding that there were no casualties or injuries.

According to the Delhi Fire Services (DFS), a call regarding the incident near Block C was received at 1.40 pm, following which one fire tender was rushed to the spot.

"Immediately, the patrolling staff rushed to the spot, and it was found that in C189 Vivek Vihar, there was fire in the electricity junction box installed in the stilt Parking of the building," a police officer said.

The police said that the intensity of the fire was increasing. The police staff, showing promptness, arranged a fire extinguisher from a nearby gas agency and a school and

There were about 5-6 cars parked in the parking lot. Timely action and promptness of local police prevented a major fire

doused the fire.

"There were about five to six cars parked in the parking lot. Timely action and promptness of local police prevented a major fire," the officer said.

The officer added that the "stop" message, indicating completion of the firefighting operation, was received at 2.40 pm. This comes days after a devastating fire ripped through a residential building in east Delhi's Vivek Vihar in the early hours of May 3, leaving nine people from two families, including a toddler, dead, with an air-conditioner blast suspected to have triggered the blaze, officials said.

Delhiite duped of Rs 80K via APK link: Cops

NEW DELHI: A 25-year-old man was arrested in Jharkhand after allegedly duping a Delhi resident of Rs 80,000 through a malicious APK link, police said on Sunday. The accused, identified as Pravin Rana from Giridih, allegedly compromised the victim's banking credentials after the APK file was downloaded. The money was later transferred and withdrawn through ATMs.

During investigation, Delhi Police traced the money trail and digital records to Jharkhand. On May 7, a police team raided the accused's hideout, but he allegedly fled through forest and hilly terrain before being chased and apprehended.

DIPIKA KIROLA

GREATER NOIDA: The Greater Noida Industrial Development Authority carried out a major anti-encroachment drive in Nanwa Rajpur village and demolished illegal constructions spread across nearly 20,000 square metres of notified land worth an estimated Rs 40 crore.

Officials said the action was taken on the directions of authority CEO NG Ravi Kumar after reports emerged that illegal colonisers were attempting plotting and unauthorised construction on Khasra No. 156 and adjoining land in the area. Teams from the authori-



ty's land records and project departments, accompanied by security personnel, used bulldozers to remove structures raised on the encroached land. The demolition exercise continued for around two hours amid tight security arrangements.

According to officials, the land mafia had allegedly been trying to develop an illegal colony on the notified land without obtaining mandatory approvals from the authority. The drive was led by OSD (Land Records) Ramnayan



Singh along with senior manager Nagendra Singh and other officials.

Additional CEO Sumit Yadav said strict action would continue against illegal constructions and unauthorised colonies in the notified area.

"No construction activity will be allowed without approval and sanctioned maps from the authority. Action will be intensified against violators," he said.

The authority directed homebuyers and investors to verify land details through the land records department before purchasing any property in Greater Noida. Officials warned residents against investing their savings in illegal colonies, saying such developments often face demolition and legal disputes.

encroachers also warned against attempting fresh construction on the cleared land, adding that any repeat violation would invite legal action.



ABVP Delhi organised a programme at the Dr Shyam Prasad Mukherjee Civic Centre to mark the birth centenary year of former ABVP national president Prof Yashwantrao Kelkar. RSS Sarkaryavah Dattatreya Hosabale attended as chief guest along with ABVP office-bearers, academics, ministers and students MPOST

POLICY TO PROVIDE STIPENDS AND COUNSELLING

Delhi govt announces Rs 3.5 cr aftercare scheme for children leaving care homes

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Sunday announced a new Aftercare Scheme for Young Persons aimed at supporting orphaned and vulnerable youth after they turn 18 and leave institutional care.

The announcement was made on the occasion of Mother's Day, with the Delhi government allocating Rs 3.5 crore for the scheme in the 2026-27 financial year.

Launching the initiative during her visit to the Village Cottage Home in Lajpat Nagar, the Chief Minister said the government's responsibility towards children does not end once they attain adulthood. "No child should ever feel alone. The government will continue to stand by them even after adulthood," she said.

The scheme has been intro-



'Mother's Day reminds us that every child deserves protection, care...'

duced under the Juvenile Justice (Care and Protection of Children) Act, 2015, and aims to help young adults transition into independent and dignified lives through education, skill development, counselling and employment support.

According to the govern-

ment, Delhi currently has 88 Child Care Institutions run by the government and NGOs, providing shelter, protection and rehabilitation to children up to the age of 18.

Around 150 to 200 young people leave these institutions every year, many of whom

TAKEAWAYS

» Under the scheme, eligible beneficiaries will receive assistance for higher education, vocational training, internships and jobs, along with monthly stipends and rehabilitation support

» Individual care plans will be prepared for each beneficiary based on need assessments

struggle with higher education, employment, financial stability and emotional support after leaving care.

CM Rekha Gupta said the new policy has been designed to bridge this gap. "Our effort is to ensure that no young person feels alone after leaving institu-

tional care and that every child gets an equal opportunity to become self-reliant," she said.

Under the scheme, eligible beneficiaries will receive assistance for higher education, vocational training, internships and jobs, along with monthly stipends and rehabilitation support. Individual care plans will be prepared for each beneficiary based on need assessments.

The Chief Minister also announced the formation of a State Aftercare Committee headed by the Secretary of the Women and Child Development Department and District Aftercare Committees under District Magistrates for monitoring and implementation.

"Mother's Day reminds us that every child deserves protection, care, guidance and the opportunity to move forward in life," the Chief Minister added.

MUKARBA CHOWK

Railways clears 2 key Delhi projects to ease congestion

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: In a major boost to Delhi's transport infrastructure, the Railways has approved two crucial projects aimed at easing chronic traffic congestion in North-West Delhi. Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Sunday announced that the Railways has granted approval for the widening of the Railway Over Bridge (ROB) at Haiderpur-Badli on Outer Ring Road and also cleared the proposed elevated loop connecting Shalimar Bagh with Sanjay Gandhi Transport Nagar.

According to the Chief Minister, both projects are expected to significantly reduce traffic bottlenecks around Mukarba Chowk, one of the busiest transit points in the capital, where thousands of commuters and commercial vehicles pass daily.

Rekha Gupta said the Delhi government is committed to building "a modern, safe and uninterrupted transport network across the capital." She



'Govt committed to building a modern, safe and uninterrupted transport network across the capital'

added that the implementation of the projects would provide "faster, safer and smoother connectivity to the public."

The approvals came after extensive technical scrutiny and coordination between the Delhi Government's Public Works Department (PWD) and Northern Railway. The Railways issued an in-princi-

ple No Objection Certificate (NOC) after finding the proposals technically feasible.

The Chief Minister said, "The Delhi Government is working at a fast pace to identify major traffic bottlenecks across the city and develop long-term solutions for them."

She noted that Mukarba Chowk, Outer Ring Road and Sanjay Gandhi Transport Nagar remain among Delhi's most congested transport corridors.

Thanking Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Railway Minister Ashwini Vaishnav for supporting the projects, Gupta said the coordinated efforts of the "double-engine government" are accelerating infrastructure reforms in the capital.

She further stated that Delhi is being developed in line with the vision of "Viksit Bharat" and "Viksit Delhi," with emphasis on seamless and future-ready transport infrastructure.

Delhi to launch five-day rescue drive for destitute persons

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government will launch a five-day special rescue and service drive for destitute persons from Monday to Saturday.

Addressing a press conference at Apna Ghar Ashram in Pooth Khurd on Saturday, the Delhi Social Welfare Minister Ravinder Indraj Singh said the campaign will be jointly organised by the Delhi government's Department of Social Welfare, Apna Ghar Ashram and Seva Bharti Delhi Prant.

“The drive for needy, helpless, destitute persons will be conducted across all 13 dists

Singh said the campaign for needy, helpless and destitute persons will be conducted across all 13 districts of the national capital from May 11 to 15.

He said the campaign aims to rescue destitute individuals from different parts of the city and bring them to shelter homes, where arrangements will be made for their treatment, care and rehabilitation.

According to the minister, 19 vehicles will be deployed for the rescue operation across Delhi, and more than 300 people are expected to receive assistance during the five-day drive.

A 'one window system' has been set up for the smooth implementation of the campaign, with the Department of Social Welfare coordinating the operation and ensur-

ing support throughout the exercise. He also appreciated the work being carried out by Apna Ghar Ashram, saying the organisation not only rescues destitute persons but also facilitates their treatment, rehabilitation and reunion with families after recovery.

The minister said several social organisations, including Seva Bharti, are extending support to the campaign.

He appealed to media organisations and members of the public to cooperate in the initiative and help reach people in need.

L-G urges people to follow traffic rules & asks police to intensify enforcement drive

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Sunday urged people to follow traffic rules and cooperate with the traffic police in ensuring safer and smoother movement on city roads.

In a post on X, Sandhu said adherence to traffic regulations is an essential civic responsibility and important for reducing congestion, preventing accidents and lowering air pollution caused by vehi-



cles stuck in traffic snarls. "I have directed traffic police to expand its enforcement drive across Delhi. You can also empower this movement by using the 'Traffic Prahari' app to report these violations and

Responsible parking, wearing helmets & seatbelts reflect our concern for fellow citizens...

earn rewards for your contribution to road safety," he said.

The lieutenant governor appealed to people to avoid wrong-side driving, signal jumping and dangerous jaywalking, while also stressing

responsible parking and the use of helmets and seatbelts.

"Simple actions such as responsible parking and wearing helmets and seatbelts reflect our concern for fellow citizens as well as our own families," he said. Sandhu said a decongested and safer Delhi could be achieved through collective efforts and a commitment to basic traffic discipline.

He also called upon residents to support the authorities in building a "better capital for all".

Delhi Metro partners with Airtel payments bank for mobility card

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Metro travel in Delhi is set to become faster and more convenient as the Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC) has partnered with Airtel Payments Bank to launch co-branded RuPay 'On-The-Go' NCMC cards, allowing commuters to travel across metro networks, buses and other transit systems nationwide using a single card.

The announcement was made at the DMRC headquarters in the presence of DMRC Managing Director Vikas Kumar and Airtel Payments Bank MD and CEO Anubrata Biswas along with senior officials from both organisations.

The newly launched co-branded cards include Debit Cards and PPI-MTS (Prepaid Payment Instrument for Mass

Transit Systems) Cards enabled with National Common Mobility Card (NCMC) technology. The initiative is aimed at supporting the Government of India's 'One Nation, One Card' vision by enabling interoperable and cashless transit payments across cities.

Unlike existing DMRC-issued cards that work only within the Delhi Metro network, the new cards can be used across multiple transit systems nationwide. The cards will be available at all metro stations within the next 10 days.

Passengers will also be able to recharge the cards digitally through the DMRC app and Airtel app, reducing the need to stand in queues at stations.

Dr. Vikas Kumar said, "DMRC has consistently focused on adopting innovative solutions to enhance passen-

ger convenience. This exclusive partnership with Airtel Payments Bank and the introduction of co-branded NCMC cards will enable seamless and interoperable travel for our commuters, not only within the Delhi Metro network but also across multiple transit systems nationwide."

Mr. Anubrata Biswas said, "Our partnership with DMRC reflects a shared vision to simplify and modernise urban mobility through secure, digital-first solutions."

DMRC clarified that existing metro cards will continue to function normally. Officials said the initiative marks a major step towards integrating digital payments with everyday public transport, making commuting smoother and more connected for passengers across India.



A female monkey with its juvenile on the occasion of Mother's Day, in New Delhi, on Sunday

PIC/PTI

TINY RIDER

NDMC marks Mother's Day with plantation drive

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: New Delhi Municipal Council Vice Chairman Kuljeet Singh Chahal on Sunday led a plantation drive at Ashirwad Old Age Home on Kali Bari Marg to mark Mother's Day, linking environmental awareness with social responsibility under the campaign #EkPedMaaKeNaam_OnSunday.

The initiative, inspired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi's "Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam" campaign, encouraged citizens to plant trees in honour of their mothers while promoting environmental conservation. Senior citizens residing at the old age home participated in the drive alongside NDMC officials and staff members, planting saplings as symbols of care, gratitude and responsibility towards nature.

Addressing the gathering, Chahal described the campaign as "a mass movement of emotional and social responsibility," stating that tree plantation was essential for securing the future of coming generations while

Vice Chairman also inspected the facilities at Ashirwad Old Age Home

paying tribute to both mothers and nature.

During his visit, Chahal also inspected the facilities at Ashirwad Old Age Home, which is operated by the Samaj Kalyan Samiti under NDMC. Established in 2016, the facility currently houses 59 senior citizens and provides accommodation, healthcare, meals and recreational facilities.

He directed officials from the civic body's welfare, civil, electrical and maintenance departments to address repair and maintenance issues within a fixed timeline. Chahal later shared lunch with the residents, who extended Mother's Day greetings and blessings to the Prime Minister. He also said NDMC would continue organising plantation drives every Sunday across New Delhi under its year-long Green Calendar initiative.

Delhi road named after Chaudhary Ramkaran Solanki

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi Cabinet Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh on Saturday paid rich tributes to late Chaudhary Ramkaran Solanki during a road naming ceremony held in Palam village, which was also attended by Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta.

Addressing the gathering, Parvesh Sahib Singh described Chaudhary Ramkaran Solanki as a leader who dedicated his life to the welfare of villages, farmers and rural communities. He said Solanki was far more than a public figure and remained deeply connected to the people of Delhi's rural belt through his simplicity and commitment to social causes.

"Chaudhary Ramkaran Solanki ji was not defined by any position... he was a thought, a commitment that stood firmly with villages, farmers, and rural society," the minister said.

He added that Solanki devoted his entire life to raising the voice of Delhi's rural

population and continued to be remembered with affection and respect by the people.

Referring to the decision to name a road after the late leader, Parvesh Sahib Singh said, "The decision by the Hon'ble Chief Minister to name a road after him is not merely a formal gesture... it is a tribute to a life dedicated to public service and rural upliftment."

The minister also stressed the need to carry forward Solanki's vision for rural development. He said both the Central Government and the Delhi Government were committed to improving infrastructure and opportunities in villages and rural areas. "It is now our responsibility to carry forward his vision. Both the Central Government and the Delhi Government are working with full commitment for the development of rural areas," he said.

The ceremony was attended by local residents, community representatives and supporters who gathered to honour the late leader's contribution to rural society.



Gopal Rai introduces water service centres

NEW DELHI: AAP MLA Gopal Rai on Saturday said "water service centres" have been set up in Babarpur constituency to provide relief to people working outdoors amid rising temperatures.

The centres will provide round-the-clock access to drinking water stored in earthen pots for labourers, auto-rickshaw and e-rickshaw drivers, homeless persons, pedestrians, delivery

workers, street vendors, security guards and sanitation workers, Rai said.

In a post on X, AAP leader Gopal Rai said the initiative was launched amid severe heat conditions linked to the "Super El Niño" effect. Caps, gamchhas, ORS packets and plants were also distributed during the campaign. He said supporting vulnerable people during extreme weather was a collective responsibility.

MP0ST

POLICE PROBE THREAT LINK

B'luru: Two gelatin sticks recovered near PM Modi's programme route

OUR CORRESPONDENT

BENGALURU: Two gelatin sticks were recovered from a roadside near PM Narendra Modi's programme venue on the outskirts of Bengaluru on Sunday, triggering heightened security measures and an intensive police investigation into their origin and whether there was any larger conspiracy behind their presence.

The gelatin sticks were discovered during security checks near Tataguni under Kaggalipura police station limits, along a route connected to the PM's movement schedule. The discovery was made shortly before he arrived in the area as part of extensive route sanitisation. Modi was in Bengaluru to attend the 45th foundation day celebrations at the Art of Living Foundation centre on Kanakapura Road near Kaggalipura. "On Sunday morning,



People gather during PM Narendra Modi's, unseen, public meeting, at the Hindustan Aeronautics Limited Airport, in Bengaluru

before the PM's arrival, during checking, two gelatin sticks were found on the side of a footpath nearly three kilometres away from the main venue. Further investigation is on," a police statement said.

The recovery came amid a seven-layer security arrangement for the PM's visit, with police and security agencies conducting route inspections

for nearly a week in advance.

Modi landed at HAL Airport at around 10.25 am and attended a programme near the airport before travelling by helicopter to the Art of Living venue, where he participated in an event alongside spiritual leader Sri Sri Ravi Shankar.

Earlier that morning, at around 7, Bengaluru's Koramangala police station

Highlights

- » Modi was in Bengaluru to attend the 45th foundation day celebrations at the Art of Living Foundation centre on Kanakapura Road near Kaggalipura
- » Earlier that morning, at around 7, Bengaluru's Koramangala police station received a threat call claiming that bomb blasts would be carried out near HAL Airport

received a threat call claiming that bomb blasts would be carried out near HAL Airport and the Art of Living Centre, where the PM was scheduled to visit.

The threat immediately put security agencies on high alert, leading to intensified anti-subotage checks and route inspections by bomb disposal squads and police personnel deployed

for bandobast duty.

At around 10.30 am, during these checks along Kanakapura Road near Thataguni, police constable Jagadish noticed a suspicious cover lying about 30 metres off the roadside near Odeyarahalli Gate. Upon inspection, police found two gelatin sticks inside it.

The discovery was immediately reported to senior officers, following which bomb disposal squads and forensic teams rushed to the location and re-scanned the entire stretch before allowing the PM's convoy to proceed.

Police later confirmed that after a comprehensive inspection of the area, no further suspicious materials were found and the route was declared safe. The PM's movement continued as scheduled.

IGP Central Range S Girish praised the alertness of the security personnel involved.

Vice Admiral Sanjay Vatsayan named Western Naval Command chief

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Vice Admiral Sanjay Vatsayan has been appointed the next chief of the Western Naval Command.

Vatsayan, currently serving as the vice chief of the Naval Staff, will succeed Vice Admiral Krishna Swaminathan at the operationally crucial command.

Swaminathan was named the next Navy Chief on Saturday. He will assume the charge of the top post as present Navy Chief Admiral Dinesh Kumar Tripathi will retire from service on May 31.

"Vice Admiral Sanjay Vatsayan has been appointed as Flag Officer Commanding-in-Chief Western Naval Command," said an official.

The Western Naval Command has its headquarters in Mumbai.

An alumnus of the National Defence Academy, Pune, Vice Admiral Vatsayan was commissioned into the Indian Navy



on January 1, 1988.

A specialist in gunnery and missile systems, he has held a wide range of command, operational and staff assignments during his distinguished career spanning more than three decades.

At sea, the flag officer has served onboard various frontline warships, including as the commissioning crew of the guided missile destroyer INS Mysore and INS Nishank

He has commanded Coast Guard ship C-05, missile vessels INS Vibhuti and INS Nashak, missile corvette INS Kuthar and guided missile frigate INS Sahyadri.w

MP govt forms judicial commission to probe Bargi Dam cruise boat tragedy

BHOPAL: The Madhya Pradesh government on Sunday constituted a one-member judicial commission to probe the Bargi Dam cruise boat tragedy that claimed 13 lives, a senior official said.

The commission was formed under the chairmanship of retired High Court judge Sanjay Dwivedi, a senior official said.

It will probe the causes of the accident, examine whether adequate rescue and relief measures were taken, and fix responsibility.

It will also make provisions for the audit and certification of boats, cruise and water sports activities under the Inland Vessels Act, 2021, and NDMA Boat Safety Guidelines, 2017.

A cruise boat, operated by the Madhya Pradesh Tourism Department, capsized on April 30, killing 13 persons, including women and children, while 28 people were rescued. AGENCIES

From Page 1 PM calls

stone for projects spanning highways, railways, textiles and industrial infrastructure. These included the four-laning of National Highway-167 on the Hyderabad-Panaji Economic Corridor, development of the Zaheerabad Industrial Area, and expansion works under the Kazipet-Vijayawada railway project. He also inaugurated a greenfield petroleum terminal in Hyderabad and infrastructure upgrades such as rail underpasses and bypasses.

A key highlight was the launch of the PM MITRA Park at Warangal, also known as the Kakatiya Mega Textile Park, developed at an estimated cost of around Rs 1,700 crore. Modi described it as India's first fully operational textile park under the scheme, aligned with the "SF" vision from farm to fibre to factory to fashion to foreign. He said the project would generate large-scale employment, particularly for women.

The Prime Minister noted that Telangana's national highway network has doubled over the past 11 years and pointed to a sharp rise in railway investment. He said the railway budget for the state now stands at Rs 5,500 crore, compared to less than Rs 1,000 crore allocated to undivided Andhra Pradesh before 2014.

Telangana Chief Minister A Revanth Reddy, who shared the platform, called for greater central support for key state projects such as metro rail expansion, the Future City initiative and the Musi river rejuvenation programme. Responding to his remarks, Modi said development should remain above politics and invited the state government to work in coordination with the Centre. "The development of states is as important as the development of the nation," he said, adding that cooperation was essential to achieve the goal of a developed India by 2047.

Telangana Governor Shiv Pratap Shukla, Union Ministers G Kishan Reddy and Bandi Sanjay Kumar, along with other leaders, were present at the event. Modi said the projects launched would strengthen connectivity, boost manufacturing and create thousands of jobs, positioning Telangana as an emerging industrial hub.

Vijay takes

time to perform and meet their expectations. He also made it clear that there was only one power centre and that was him.

He also thanked leaders from parties that supported him, including "brother" Rahul Gandhi of Congress and Left leaders, before he concluded his speech with a round of selfies he took with those who shared the dais with him and the crowd.

His Cabinet is a mix of young and experienced, with the 51-year-old actor-turned-politician's core team finding a place in his maiden ministry.

The oath-taking ceremony, reflecting the atmosphere across the city of hard-won victory and high expectations, symbolised the

arrival of a new political era, centred around Vijay's mass appeal, youth outreach and anti-establishment approach.

Although TVK on its own did not secure the majority in the 234-member Tamil Nadu Assembly, Vijay managed to get support from the Congress, VCK, CPI, CPI (M) and IUML to gather 120 MLAs and cross the 118 majority mark to form the government, an act that is seen as a demonstration of his political adaptability beyond his image of a popular actor.

TVK also draws inspiration from old Dravidian leaders and has projected itself as a protector of Tamil pride. The opening of the swearing-in ceremony included a Tamil nationalist song after Vande Mataram and the National Anthem.

Vijay's emergence in one of the most influential states in the South is expected to reshape opposition politics at the national level and alter alliance calculations ahead of the 2029 Lok Sabha elections.

The Congress, which broke its ties with the DMK to extend support to TVK, has announced that its ties with Vijay's party were for all future elections. This is the first time Congress has been part of any government in Tamil Nadu in six decades.

Actress Sanam Shetty, speaking to reporters, described the moment as a breakthrough for Tamil Nadu politics.

Seeking to identify himself as a commoner from humble origins, Vijay said he will be the sole "power centre" in his coalition government. Vijay said he was well aware about poverty and hunger as he was born as the son of an ordinary assistant film director who aspired to win in cinema by working hard.

"There is only one centre here, the centre under my leadership. A centre on this side, a power center on that side, another power center there - none of that exists, I'm telling you right now," he said.

Further, he said, "I do not hail from any royal lineage, I am like you and I am like one among you, one among your family," he said adding he was rather feeling like one of them, their son or brother.

The chief minister assured that he would be strict on women's safety. "From today itself, I will take all the necessary steps and efforts to control the drug culture. It is the responsibility of our government to protect our children from it. Similarly, I will ensure upholding law and order and assure protection for everyone."

Even those who humiliated him, those who caused him trouble, "they are also my people, are not they," he asked. Whether they are friends or enemies, all eight crore people are my people. "Are not they?"

He said his primary focus would be on ensuring basic amenities infrastructure covering education, PDS system-ration, medicine, drinking water, road and bus facilities.

Women, youth, farmers, government employees, teachers, working people, fishermen - everyone will be taken care under the TVK government.

Asserting that equality was his party's unwavering fundamental principle, Vijay said, the TVK regime will stand with "minority brothers", and there need not be any doubts about that.

Meanwhile, former West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Baner-

jee wished Vijay success after he was sworn in as the chief minister.

Banerjee said the electoral verdict reflected the "aspirations, trust and democratic will" of the people of Tamil Nadu.

"I extend my heartfelt congratulations to Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) on their impressive victory in the 2026 Tamil Nadu Assembly elections. I also convey my warm wishes to Shri Vijay on being sworn in as the Chief Minister of Tamil Nadu," Banerjee posted on X.

The Trinamool Congress supremo said she was confident that Tamil Nadu would continue on the path of "progress, welfare and inclusive development" under Vijay's leadership.

"Wishing him and his government success in serving the people with dedication and commitment," the Trinamool Congress supremo added.

Yogi expands

Bhupendra Chaudhary's elevation is being viewed as a significant move to consolidate the influential Jai vote bank in western Uttar Pradesh. Political circles are also discussing the possibility of Chaudhary being assigned the Public Works Department, which has remained with the Chief Minister since Jitin Prasada moved to the Centre.

The induction of Manoj Pandey has added a political dimension to the expansion. Pandey had rebelled against the Samajwadi Party during crucial Assembly voting and his inclusion is being interpreted as the BJP's effort to send a message to opposition leaders while expanding its influence beyond traditional party lines.

The caste composition of the new ministers reflects the BJP's electoral calculations for 2027. Among the new entrants are one Brahmin, three OBC leaders and two Dalit representatives. Krishna Paswan is expected to strengthen the party's outreach among the Pasi community, while Surendra Diler is seen as a Valmiki face. Hansraj Vishwakarma has been inducted as an OBC representative and Kailash Rajput is expected to help consolidate support among Lodh voters.

Symbolism was also visible during the swearing-in ceremony. Krishna Paswan arrived wearing a "Radhe-Radhe" scarf and raised slogans of "Jai Shri Ram" during the group photograph after the oath ceremony. Surendra Diler took oath dressed in saffron attire. Political analysts said the expansion clearly indicates that the BJP has started preparing its caste and alliance strategy for the next Assembly elections.

This is the second Cabinet expansion of the Yogi government. The first expansion took place on March 5, 2024, ahead of the Lok Sabha elections, when SBSP chief Om Prakash Rajbhar, former Samajwadi Party leader Dara Singh Chauhan, RLD quota minister Anil Kumar and BJP leader Sunil Sharma were inducted into the ministry.

With Sunday's expansion, the total strength of the Uttar Pradesh Council of Ministers has risen to 60, including the chief minister. Political observers believe the reshuffle marks the BJP's formal push towards social and regional consolidation ahead of the 2027

Assembly battle.

Himanta Sarma

Asom Gana Parishad and Bodoland People's Front, secured a decisive mandate in the 126-member Assembly, winning 102 seats. Of these, the BJP accounted for 82 seats, while the AGP and BPF won 10 seats each.

Sarma, who first assumed office in 2021, is poised to become the first non-Congress leader in Assam to serve two consecutive terms as chief minister. "I have been elected as the BJP's legislative party leader. The NDA parties, BPF and AGP, also elected me as their leader," he said, adding that he had the support and signatures of all 102 NDA MLAs.

Support letters were also submitted by AGP chief Atul Bora and BPF leader Rihon Daimari.

This marks the third straight term for the NDA in Assam since it first came to power in 2016 under former chief minister Sarbananda Sonowal. Union minister JP Nadda and Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini, who were appointed as central observers, accompanied Sarma during the meeting with the governor.

Speaking to reporters, Nadda said the election results reflected public backing for the prime minister's development agenda and credited the outgoing government for implementing welfare schemes effectively. "In the next five years, the PM will introduce various schemes, which will be implemented in Assam by Himanta Biswa Sarma," he said.

Earlier, Sarma's name was proposed by eight MLAs, including Ranjeet Kumar Dass, Ajanta Neog, Ashok Singhal and Pijush Hazarika, and was accepted unanimously. Addressing party members, Sarma thanked voters for the mandate and said the new government would work with renewed energy for the welfare and development of all sections of society.

Kerala CM

the selection of the next chief minister of Kerala.

Responding to reporters' questions in Thiruvananthapuram, Muralaeddharan said the current debate over the chief minister's post has not overshadowed the United Democratic Front's (UDF) electoral victory in the southern state.

The top brass of the Congress held a meeting for more than three hours in Delhi on Saturday to discuss government formation in Kerala. The meeting convened by Kharge at his residence was attended by Gandhi, All India Congress Committee (AICC) general secretary in-charge of Kerala Deepa Dasmunshi, general secretary (organisation) K C Venugopal and senior leaders from the state Ramesh Chennithala and V D Satheesan.

Venugopal, Satheesan and Chennithala are considered to be the frontrunners for the chief minister's post.

"Everyone expressed their views and Rahulji heard them patiently. The final decision on the chief minister will be taken by the Congress high command and

whatever decision is made will be accepted by all," Chennithala had said after the meeting.

Kerala Congress chief Sunny Joseph and senior observers Ajay Maken and Mukul Wasnik were also present at the meeting.

Venugopal was already seen to be ahead of others in the race. The Congress, however, has to decide on choosing a central leader as Venugopal or a local leader who enjoys support on the ground.

Satheesan and Ramesh Chennithala have strong pockets of influence in the southern state. Satheesan has the support of the Congress's ally IUML for the chief minister's post.

These factors culminated into a poster war and street protests by workers in favour of their leaders. The Congress has 63 MLAs in the 140-member Kerala assembly; IUML has 22 seats and so its opinion will matter. Kerala Congress (KEC) won eight seats, and the Revolutionary Socialist Party (RSP) took three seats. The UDF has won a total of 102 seats, which is more than a two-thirds majority.

Kerala Congress leaders have said Satheesan played a big role as the Leader of Opposition in the outgoing Kerala assembly and laid the groundwork for the ouster of the Pinarayi Vijayan-led Left Democratic Front (LDF).

"Very soon, in due time, we will get our final decision from our high command," Dasmunshi had told reporters after the meeting when asked about the new chief minister of Kerala.

"Congress chief Mallikarjun Kharge and Rahul Gandhi will take the final decision," she had said when asked as to "who in the high command will take the call".

Referring to protests by various factions in the Congress-led UDF alliance in Kerala for the last two days over the issue of the party's chief-ministerial nominee, she had said some unruly incidents have happened and those are not part of the Congress culture.

Satheesan had said the Congress has scored a historic win in the Kerala Assembly polls due to the hard work of all workers but subsequently, there have been demonstrations, social-media campaigns and even flexboards have come up regarding the selection of the chief minister, creating an image of divisions in the party. "All of us are requesting together that please do not carry out such demonstrations and campaigns for anyone of us. It will hurt the Congress workers, the UDF activists and the large number of people who have voted for us," he had said.

Endorsing his views, Venugopal had said people have given a huge victory to the party and they want a UDF government that would work for them. "There have been some unfortunate incidents. These should be ended," he had said.

Supporters of both Venugopal and Satheesan have put up posters and banners of their leaders in Delhi as well as in Thiruvananthapuram.

Iran sends

"every chance we possibly can before going back to hostilities," the US ambassador to the United Nations, Mike Waltz, told ABC. Iran's new supreme leader, Mojtaba Khamenei, who has not

been seen or heard publicly since the war began, "issued new and decisive directives for the continuation of operations and the powerful confrontation with the enemies" while meeting with the head of the joint military command, the state broadcaster reported, with no details.

Meanwhile, the fragile ceasefire was tested when a drone ignited a small fire on a ship off Qatar and the United Arab Emirates and Kuwait reported drones entering their airspace. The UAE blamed Iran. No casualties were reported, and no one immediately claimed responsibility.

Qatar's Foreign Ministry called it a "dangerous and unacceptable escalation that threatens the security and safety of maritime trade routes and vital supplies in the region."

Iran and armed allied groups like Hezbollah in Lebanon have used drones to carry out hundreds of strikes since the war began with US and Israeli attacks on February 28.

Trump has reiterated threats to resume full-scale bombing if Iran does not accept an agreement to reopen the strait and roll back its nuclear program. Iran has largely blocked the strategic waterway that's key to the global flow of oil, natural gas and fertilizer since the war began, rattling world markets.

The US in turn has blockaded Iranian ports and on Friday struck two Iranian oil tankers it said were trying to breach the blockade. Iran's Revolutionary Guard navy says any attack on Iranian oil tankers or commercial vessels would be met with a "heavy assault" on one of the US bases in the region and enemy ships.

The American military said Sunday that it has turned back 61 commercial vessels and disabled four since the blockade began April 13.

Another sticking point in negotiations is Iran's highly enriched uranium. The UN nuclear agency says Iran has more than 440 kilograms (970 pounds) of uranium that is enriched up to 60 per cent purity, a short, technical step from weapons-grade levels.

In an interview with state media posted late Saturday, an Iranian military spokesperson said its forces were on "full readiness" to protect nuclear sites where uranium is stored.

"We considered it possible that they might intend to steal it through infiltration operations or heli-borne operations," Brig. Gen. Akrami Nia told the IRNA news agency.

Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu in an excerpt of an interview with CBS scheduled to air later Sunday said the war isn't over because the enriched uranium needs to be taken out of Iran. "Trump has said to me, I want to go in there; and I think it can be done physically," he said.

Russian President Vladimir Putin said Saturday that Moscow's proposal to take enriched uranium from Iran to help negotiate a settlement remains on the table.

The majority of Iran's highly enriched uranium is likely at its Isfahan nuclear complex, the International Atomic Energy Agency director-general told The Associated Press last month. The facility was bombed by US-Israeli airstrikes in the 12-day war last year and faced less intense attacks this year.

Pakistan oversaw face-to-

face talks between the U.S. and Iran last month and continues to pursue mediation. In rare public comments, army chief Field Marshal Asim Munir said Islamabad remains committed to helping end the conflict. Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif spoke by phone with his Qatari counterpart.

The UAE's Defence Ministry said it shot down two drones and blamed Iran.

In Kuwait, Defence Ministry spokesperson Brig Gen Saud Abdulaziz Al Otaibi said hostile drones entered Kuwait's airspace and forces responded "in accordance with established procedures." The ministry did not say where the drones came from.

Qatar's Defence Ministry said a drone targeted a commercial ship coming from Abu Dhabi, setting a small fire that was extinguished. The United Kingdom Maritime Trade Operations Center said the attack happened 23 nautical miles (43 kilometers) northeast of the capital, Doha. It gave no details about the ship's owner or origin, and there was no claim of responsibility.

Several attacks against ships in the Persian Gulf have occurred over the past week, and a US effort to "guide" ships through the strait was soon paused.

South Korea announced initial findings from an investigation that said two unidentified airborne objects struck the South Korean-operated vessel HMM NAMU about one minute apart while it was anchored in the Strait of Hormuz last week, causing an explosion and fire. A foreign ministry spokesperson said officials have yet to determine who was responsible.

U'khand's Pauri: Classes suspended after leopards seen prowling near school

OUR CORRESPONDENT

PAURI GARHWAL: Authorities declared that Monday and Tuesday would be holidays at a government primary school in Ekeshwar block here after two leopards appeared near its campus, officials said.

The incident occurred on Saturday at 7.30 am when students of Government Primary School, Sason, were gathering for the morning assembly.

A local taxi driver, Shubham Rawat, spotted the leopards and sounded his vehicle horn to alert the staff. Teachers scrambled to shield the students inside classrooms while villagers used stones and noise to chase the animals into the forest.

Following the close shave, the Block Education Officer ordered the school to remain closed for two days, starting Monday, to ensure student safety.

Vikas Chandra Kainthola, an assistant teacher, told news agency, "The assembly was about to begin when we were alerted to the leopards standing right at our wall. We acted instantly to secure the children." The incident has heightened fear across 14 neighbouring schools, including Maso, Mawanidhar and Pipli.



EDITORIAL
BEYOND
THE MAT

The image of Vinesh Phogat standing exhausted beside the weighing scale in Paris became one of the defining sport-ing moments for India in 2024. It cap-tured heartbreak, sacrifice and the brutal margins that separate triumph from disaster in elite sport. For many Indians, Vinesh was not merely an athlete who missed an Olympic medal by 100 grams; she was also the face of a rebellion against institu-tional arrogance in Indian wrestling. That is precisely why the latest confrontation between the Wrestling Federation of India and Vinesh carries significance beyond a disciplinary dispute. It touches upon ques-tions of governance, fairness, athlete accountabil-ity and the lingering scars left by one of the ugliest phases in Indian sport.

The Wrestling Federation of India has now issued a detailed show-cause notice accusing Vinesh of violating anti-doping return rules, engaging in indiscipline and damaging the repu-tation of Indian wrestling. The federation insists that rules under the United World Wrestling framework are non-negotiable and that any ath-lete returning from retirement must complete a mandatory six-month notice period while remain-ing available for anti-doping testing. On paper, the argument appears procedural and legitimate. Sporting regulations cannot be selectively enforced depending on an athlete's popularity or public image. If the federation overlooked similar viola-tions by others while acting strictly against Vinesh, questions of bias would naturally emerge. But if identical standards were applied previously to wrestlers such as Aman Sehrawat and Neha Sang-wan for weight-related lapses, the WFI can reason-ably claim consistency in disciplinary action.

Yet the matter cannot be viewed in isolation from the troubled history between Vinesh and the federation. Indian wrestling spent nearly two years trapped in public controversy after leading wrestlers accused former WFI chief Brij Bhushan Sharan Singh of sexual harassment and institu-tional intimidation. Vinesh was among the most visible faces of that protest movement. The agita-tion divided Indian sport, drew global attention and exposed deep structural weaknesses in athlete protection mechanisms. Even today, a trust deficit continues to exist between many wrestlers and the federation leadership. In such an atmosphere, every disciplinary step risks appearing political, even when backed by technical rules. That percep-tion problem is not minor. Sporting federations derive legitimacy not only from regulations, but also from public confidence that those regulations are being enforced impartially and transparently.

At the same time, Vinesh herself cannot escape difficult questions. Elite sport demands relent-less discipline, especially in an era where anti-dop-ing systems operate with strict global scrutiny. The “whereabouts” requirement under WADA-linked frameworks is not an administrative formality; it exists to preserve integrity in international competi-tion. If anti-doping officials were genuinely unable to locate her for testing after she indicated a return to training, the issue becomes serious regardless of her stature. Likewise, the Paris Olympic disqualifi-cation remains a painful reminder that at the high-est level, preparation includes weight management as much as technical excellence. India's emotional investment in that Olympic final cannot erase the fact that sporting rules are unforgiving. One may sympathise with the physical and mental toll endured by athletes cutting weight, yet governing bodies cannot afford ambiguity in applying regula-tions meant to ensure fairness.

However, the WFI must also recognise the dan-ger of appearing excessively punitive or retrospec-tive. Several allegations included in the notice relate to incidents dating back to 2024, during a period when the federation itself was under administra-tive uncertainty and an ad-hoc panel managed the sport. Raising old grievances now, precisely when Vinesh attempts a comeback, inevitably creates suspicion regarding intent. If the federation truly believes there was a broader pattern of indisci-pline, why were those concerns not pursued earlier through a transparent disciplinary mechanism? Delayed accountability weakens institutional cred-ibility. Moreover, public communication matters enormously in such sensitive disputes. The language used by sporting bodies should focus on procedure, evidence and corrective action rather than framing athletes as enemies of the sport. Wrestling in India has already suffered reputational damage through administrative infighting; it does not need further polarisation between institutions and athletes.

The larger lesson from this episode is that Indian sport still struggles to separate governance from personality-driven conflict. Federations often function defensively, athletes increasingly turn to public confrontation, and disputes quickly evolve into media spectacles shaped by political loyal-ties. This culture benefits nobody. India aspires to become a major sporting power, but that ambition requires institutions that are professionally cred-ible, athlete-centric and legally robust. Rules must be enforced consistently, but athletes must also feel protected from selective targeting and opaque decision-making. Vinesh Phogat deserves a fair hearing, free from vendetta or sensationalism. Equally, the federation has the right to demand compliance with international regulations. The path forward lies neither in hero worship nor insti-tutional rigidity, but in restoring trust through transparency, consistency and due process. Indian wrestling has endured enough turmoil. What it needs now is not another public battle, but a mature resolution that places the future of the sport above individual rivalries.

LIVING
HERITAGE



GAJENDRA SINGH
SHEKHAWAT

THE WRITER IS THE
UNION MINISTER
FOR CULTURE
AND TOURISM,
GOVERNMENT
OF INDIA

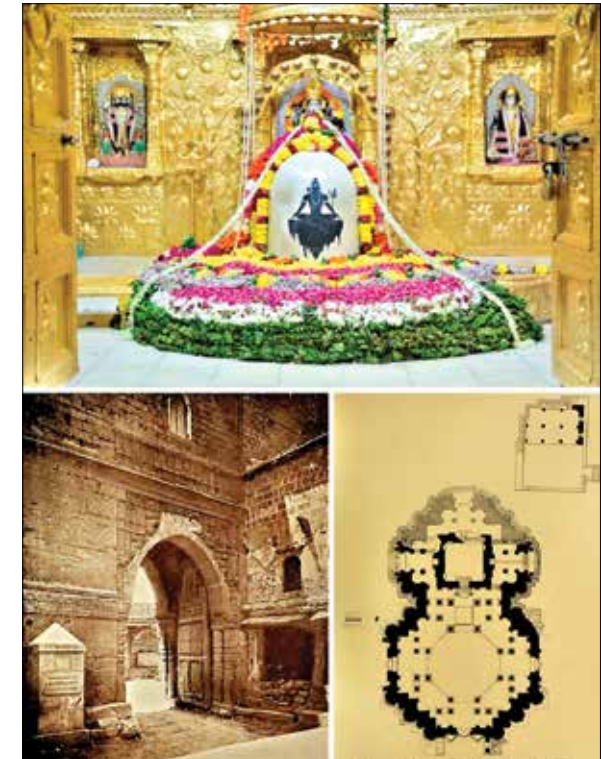
Somnath's
endurance lies not
merely in stone,
but in the values
carried from one
generation to another

न हन्यते हन्यमाने शरीरे
(आत्मा is not destroyed when
the body is destroyed.)
Bhagavad Gita 2.20

The essence carried by this shloka from *Srimad Bhagvad Gita* and from the civilisational wis-dom enclosed in the Indian scrip-tures and traditions, is reflected in the essence of Somnath Temple located at Somanatha-Pattan on the southern shore of Kathiawad (historic region in the southwest-ern region of the present-day state of Gujarat). Regarded as the first among the twelve *Jyotirlingas*, many a time its walls have borne the brunt of battle at the hands of barbarian invaders, only to rise again and resume the drums and bells of worship.

Across more than a thou-sand years of Indian history, Sanātana Dharma - understood as a diverse, decentralised con-stellation of religious practices, philosophies, rituals, and institu-tions - has experienced repeated moments of disruption arising from political conquest, regime change, and shifting structures of power. These disruptions included the destruction or repur-posing of temples, monasteries, and centres of learning, as well as the displacement of patron-age networks that had sustained religious institutions. Yet, despite these ruptures, the broader reli-gious tradition endured, adapted, and reasserted itself across time. The historical significance of this endurance lies not in claims of uninterrupted dominance, but in the capacity of religious life to survive institutional loss and political vulnerability.

From the early medieval period, temples functioned not only as places of worship but also as economic, cultural, and political centres. Their close asso-ciation with ruling elites made them vulnerable during periods of military conflict. The raid on the Somnath Temple by Mahmud of Ghazni is among the most dis-cussed examples. Persian chron-



Somnath represents India's ability to preserve faith, culture and collective memory despite political upheaval

icles celebrated the event as a victory, while later Indian tradi-tions emphasised loss, resistance, and eventual restoration. What is historically verifiable is that the temple did not disappear from religious life; it was rebuilt under regional rulers such as the Chau-lukyas and continued to attract devotion. Similar patterns are vis-ible elsewhere.

The history of Somnath must never be reduced to a single epi-sode. From ancient times, Prab-hasa Patan has been a sacred geography. Patan, known by dif-ferent names in different sources, including Prabhas-Pattan, Shiva-Pattan and Prabhas-Tirtha, is an ancient town on the east of which three beautiful rivers merge at a Triveni - held sacred, mark-ing the cremation of the body of Lord Krishna. In the neighbour-hood lies the Vairagya Kshetra and Gopi Tulow (from where people procure the Gopi Chan-

dan). A sacred pilgrimage to this region is considered incomplete without visiting this sacred land. One can find details of the ruins found in this region in the 'Report on the Antiquities of Kathiawad and Kachh, and The Antiquities of the town of Dabhoi in Gujarat'.

Somnath represents a rare confluence of Shaiva and Vaish-nava traditions, repeatedly reminding us that the Indian heritage has always been plural and inclusive.

The modern chapter in the history of Somnath in indepen-dent India began on Kartak Sud 1, Diwali - 12 November 1947, barely months after the unfortu-nate Partition, when our first Dep-uty Prime Minister and Home Minister visited this sacred land of Somnath. Accompanied by senior leaders and great person-alities, Sardar Patel took a decisive pledge of a free India undertaking the reconstruction of this historic

temple. What resulted next was the institutional framework that carried the national conscious-ness. Somnath was reconstructed, conceived as more than a rebuild-ing of a shrine, as a cultural and intellectual centre.

The consecration ceremony performed early morning on May 11, 1951, in the august presence of Hon'ble President of India Shri Rajendra Prasad reaffirmed the shared cultural memory of the nation.

As India advances towards India@2047, these civilizational values assume renewed relevance. In an era marked by technologi-cal acceleration and geopolitical uncertainty, India's gift to humanity lies in demonstrating that progress need not abandon compassion, and power need not forsake restraint. The endur-ance of Somnath reminds us that true leadership — national and global — is sustained not only by strength, but by wisdom, mem-ory, and an unwavering commit-ment to shared human dignity.

Somnath Swabhiman Parv 2026-27 is envisaged as a year-long national commemoration anchored in the civilisational legacy, spiritual resilience, and cultural continuity symbolised by Shri Somnath Jyotirlinga at Prabhas Patan, Gujarat. Somnath occupies a unique place in India's civilisational history. Despite repeated destruction across cen-turies, the temple was rebuilt time and again through the collective resolve of the people, emerging as a living testament to cultural con-tinuity, spiritual resilience, and national self-belief.

Somnath Swabhiman Parv (that began from 8-11 Janu-ary 2026) marks two signif-icant milestones in India's civilizational journey: one thou-sand years since the first recorded attack on the Somnath Temple in 1026, and seventy-five years since the reopening of the recon-structed temple in 1951 following Independence.

Thereby, positioning Somnath as a unifying national symbol of

endurance, collective memory, and cultural self-respect. The commemoration shall culminate in a major national event on 11 May 2026, supported by a struc-tured sequence of yatras, cultural productions, dialogues, educa-tional initiatives, and coordinated programmes across Jyotirlingas, States, Union Territories, dis-tricts, and shivalayas nationwide.

Under the leadership of Hon'ble Prime Minister, Shri Nar-endra Modi, who also serves as Chairperson of the Shri Somnath Trust, Somnath has entered a renewed phase of holistic revival. Governance reforms, infrastruc-ture enhancement, heritage con-servation, and cultural initiatives have strengthened the temple's role as a living spiritual cen-tre. Sustainability measures and women-led service initiatives fur-ther reflect how civilizational val-ues are being expressed through contemporary responsibility and inclusion.

The Somnath Swabhi-man Parv creates a connection between modern society and the deeper essence of its cul-ture through cultural, spiritual, and educational activities. It is a reminder to every generation that the temple of Somnath is not just about its physical exist-ence; its true essence lies in the values and the responsibility that are consciously transferred from one generation to another. In this spirit, Somnath stands today not only as a restored shrine, but as a living tirtha.

As Bharat continues its jour-ney in the twenty-first century, the spirit of Somnath offers a guiding principle: that a civil-ization remains strong when it is rooted, remains relevant when it is adaptable, and remains unified when it is inclusive.

May the legacy of Somnath continue to inspire us - to build with purpose, to act with balance, and to move forward with a deep awareness of who we are.

Jai Somnath!
Vande Mataram!
Views expressed are personal

Somnath and India's Soul

As Somnath Swabhiman Parv marks historic milestones, the temple's journey re-minds India that civilisation survives through memory, renewal and shared dignity

Age of Indian Innovation

From Pokhran to quantum technologies, India's scientific journey now reflects ambition, self-reliance and the pursuit of innovation-led growth

National Technology Day - 'विज्ञान Tech', celebrated on May 11, commemorates India's landmark technological achievement marked by the suc-cessful Pokhran nuclear tests of 1998. The occasion also high-lights the nation's enduring com-mitment to scientific innovation, technological advancement, and the synergy between science, society, and industry in shap-ing India's development journey.

Over the last decade, under the leadership of Hon'ble Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi, India's technological ecosys-tem has witnessed unprece-dented growth, marked by rapid innovation, expanding digital infrastructure, and significant advancements across emerging sectors. There has been a greater emphasis on self-reliance and the translation of scientific inno-vations into real-world impact. Considerable progress has been made in frontier technology-driven areas such as quantum communication, space, biotech-nology, artificial intelligence, semiconductors, renewable energy, and climate-resilient systems. Biomufacturing is a key technology for Viksit Bharat, enabling sustainable inno-vation, healthcare resilience, and a strong bioeconomy through the production of high-value biolog-ics, vaccines, fuels, and materials using biological systems. India's success with the Chandrayaan-3 mission and recent milestones, such as the attainment of criti-cality in the indigenous Proto-type Fast Breeder Reactor at Kalpakkam,

further highlight the coun-try's progress in strategic sectors and its commitment to long-term technological sovereignty.

This progress is also reflected in various key national metrics. India has significantly improved its position in the Global Innova-tion Index released by the World Intellectual Property Organisa-tion (WIPO), rising from 81st in



As India moves towards 2047, science, technology and innovation will drive growth, strategic autonomy, sustainability and societal transformation nationwide

2015 to 38th in 2025. The number of patents granted in the country has increased from a few thou-sand in 2014-15 to around 1.5 lakh in 2025. India's startup eco-system has also expanded sig-nificantly, with more than 1.5 lakh DPIIT-recognised startups across sectors, including nearly fifteen thousand working in emerging technology domains such as AI, robotics, and addi-tive manufacturing. The transfor-mation is further evident in the expansion of renewable energy capacity to over 250 GW of non-fossil sources and the growth of the bioeconomy from USD 10 billion to USD 195 billion in a decade.

Policy reforms implemented by the Government over the past decade have played a crucial role in this transformation. These include the rapid expansion of the startup and incubation eco-system, opening strategic sectors such as space and nuclear energy to private players, and the estab-lishment of enabling frameworks such as the ANRE, the BioE3 (Biotechnology for Economy, Environment and Employment) Policy, and the recently launched Rs 1 lakh crore Research Devel-opment and Innovation (RDI) Fund. These initiatives have strengthened India's innova-tion architecture and reinforced

the focus on translating sci-en-tific outcomes into societal and economic impact. Science is now moving from laboratories to markets and from ideas to impact.

The Government is providing the right impetus through proac-tive policies, removal of outdated regulations, and is successfully creating an ethical yet level-playing field for Indian innova-tors. It is also moving beyond being merely a primary funder to becoming a primary enabler. With the establishment of the Anusandhan National Research Foundation (ANRF) as the central apex body designed to provide strategic direction for research, innovation, and entre-preneurship across India, the aim is to transition India into a knowledge-driven economy and a global leader in innovation. The broader objective is to ensure that this journey is powered by indigenous intellectual property, ethical frameworks, and a “whole of government” approach for a “whole of society” commitment to science and technology.

‘विज्ञान Tech’ reflects this jour-ney, with science as the foun-dational core, technology as the enabler, and innovation as the outcome. The national exhibi-tion, scheduled for May 11, 2026, at the BRIC–National Institute

of Immunology (NII), New Delhi, showcases over 350 deep technologies developed indig-enously by leading national research institutions and labo-ratories under 14 Ministries and Departments of the Government of India. These indigenous tech-nologies span key thematic sec-tors including Biopharma and Health Technologies, Bioin-dustrial and Green Chemicals, Space and Geospatial Technol-ogies, Climate and Agri-Food Technologies, Deep-Tech Mate-rials and Advanced Engineer-ing Technologies, Electronics, Semiconductors and Energy, and Deep Sea and Atmospheric Tech-nologies. Many of these technol-ogies have already been licensed or commercialised, while others will soon be available for licens-ing and deployment.

The common thread across these innovations is the shift from siloed research to an integrated, ecosystem-driven approach. Public research insti-tutions are increasingly working closely with startups and indus-try to ensure that technologies move rapidly from laboratories to markets.

India's next phase of tech-nological growth would require deeper integration between aca-demia, industry, startups, and government, beginning from the stage of conceptualisation of research programs itself. Strong-er industry-academia partner-ships can improve alignment of research with national prior-ities, market needs, and societal challenges, while fundamental research must continue to be encouraged for breakthrough innovation and scientific excel-lence. National institutions and laboratories would also need to work in a more collaborative and mission-mode manner to address emerging challenges in frontier areas such as artificial intelligence, robotics, advanced materials, quantum technolo-gies, space exploration, and medical technologies.

As science and technology evolve at an unprecedented pace, regulatory frameworks must also become more adaptive, stream-lined and innovation-friendly. Emerging domains such as cell and gene therapy, monoclonal biologics, synthetic biology, and autonomous systems require agile and evidence-based regu-latory frameworks that balance innovation, safety, and ethics. Dynamic mechanisms such as regulatory sandboxes can help accelerate responsible innova-tion. Greater participation of States (e.g. BioE3 Cells) and regional innovation ecosystems, especially in Tier-II and Tier-III cities, can help promote a more decentralised and bottom-up approach to scientific and tech-nological development aligned with regional priorities and chal-lenges, ensuring that science and technology become powerful instruments for improving the quality of life across the country.

The transformative power of science and technology will play a pivotal role in realising the vision of Viksit Bharat by driving economic growth, improving govern-ance, enhancing productivity, and fostering inclusive devel-opment. Government initiatives such as the India Semiconduc-tor Mission and the National Quantum Mission, alongside advancements in biomanufac-turing, precision biotherapeu-tics and AI-enabled solutions in agriculture and healthcare, high-light India's strategic focus on strengthening innovation and leadership in emerging technolo-gies. India is transitioning from being primarily a consumer of technology to becoming a global hub of innovation.

As India advances towards 2047, Science, Technology and Innovation will continue to play an increasingly important role in catalysing economic growth, strategic autonomy, societal transformation, and a sustain-able future.

Views expressed are personal

TOURISM, HEALTHCARE, INFRA IN FOCUS

EAM’s visit: India inks eight MoUs with Trinidad and Tobago

MPOST BUREAU

PORT OF SPAIN: India and Trinidad and Tobago have signed eight agreements in sectors including tourism, healthcare, infrastructure and Ayurveda during External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar’s two-day visit to the Caribbean nation, according to an official statement.

Jaishankar, who visited the Caribbean nation on May 8-9, held talks with Prime Minister Kamla Persad-Bissessar and other senior leaders on expanding bilateral cooperation and reviewed progress on announcements made during Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s visit to Trinidad and Tobago last year, India’s Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said in its statement on Sunday.

“A total of 8 MoUs were signed between the two sides in the areas of tourism, solarisation of T&T’s Ministry of Foreign and CARICOM Affairs building, vector control, infrastructure upgrade of Nelson Island where the Indian immigrants were stayed initially, and for setting up of an Indian Chair on Ayurveda at the University of the West Indies,” it said.

In the presence of Persad-Bissessar, Jaishankar handed over the first batch of 2,000 laptops to selected schoolchildren and inaugurated an agro-processing facility for which machinery worth USD 1 million was provided by India last year.

Persad-Bissessar and Jaishankar jointly inaugurated Trinidad and Tobago’s National Prosthetics Centre in Penal.

According to the MEA statement, discussions also covered cooperation in infrastructure, security, forensics, healthcare



India's External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar with Trinidad and Tobago Prime Minister Kamla Persad-Bissessar during a visit to Nelson Island, near Port of Spain

HIGHLIGHTS

» Jaishankar, who visited the Caribbean nation on May 8-9, held talks with Prime Minister Kamla Persad-Bissessar and other senior leaders on expanding bilateral cooperation and reviewed progress on announcements made during Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s visit to Trinidad and Tobago last year

» Jaishankar handed over the first batch of 2,000 laptops to selected schoolchildren and inaugurated an agro-processing facility for which machinery worth USD 1 million was provided by India last year

» Persad-Bissessar and Jaishankar jointly inaugurated Trinidad and Tobago’s National Prosthetics Centre

and capacity building.

The two sides reaffirmed coordination in regional and multilateral forums, including on issues concerning the Global South.

The MEA said the visit gave “fresh impetus” to India’s ties with Trinidad and Tobago.

Elvish Yadav gets extortion threat of ₹10 cr

MPOST BUREAU

GURUGRAM: Bigg Boss OTT 2 winner Elvish Yadav has received an extortion threat of Rs 10 crore from a foreign WhatsApp number, with the sender identifying himself as Randeep Malik having “close links” with the Lawrence Bishnoi gang, police said on Sunday.

Family members of Yadav alleged that the accused threatened to shoot him if he did not pay the money within two days.

Police have lodged an FIR based on a complaint filed by Yadav at the Sector 56 police station.

In his complaint, Yadav said he received a WhatsApp call from a foreign number on May 5 but could not answer it at the time.

He later received a message on WhatsApp from the same number containing threatening words.

“The sender identified himself as Randeep Malik and claimed to be a close associate of the Lawrence Bishnoi gang. He demanded Rs 10 crore to be paid within two days, and threatened to shoot me if I did not pay the sum,” Yadav said in his complaint.

The same threatening message was also sent to his father’s mobile number, he alleged.

The case has been transferred to the Crime Branch, a senior police officer said, adding that efforts are underway to trace the source of the call.

Yadav is currently out of Gurugram for the shoot of a show called ‘Laughter Safe’.

The social media influencer, who won the second season of Bigg Boss OTT in 2023, has been in the news for varied reasons in recent years.

Last August, unidentified gunmen fired more than two dozen rounds outside his residence in Sector 56. Delhi Police later arrested two shooters in connection with the case.

Before that, Yadav was arrested in March 2024 on charges of supplying snake venom for rave parties. The Supreme Court quashed the FIR and legal proceedings related to the case in March this year.

Flood crisis management teams should be constituted in every state: Amit Shah

HM reviews country’s preparedness to deal with potential floods, heatwaves

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: Flood crisis management teams (FCMTs) should be constituted and activated in every state, Union Home minister Amit Shah said on Sunday while chairing a high-level meeting in the national capital to review the country’s preparedness for floods, heat waves and other climate-related disasters.

He also stressed the need for a comprehensive and coordinated disaster management strategy.

The meeting focused on strengthening disaster response mechanisms through better coordination among Central and state agencies, with special emphasis on flood forecasting, early warning systems and preparedness ahead of the monsoon season. Shah highlighted the importance of adopting a unified approach



HM Amit Shah reviews country’s preparedness to deal with potential floods and heat waves during a high-level meeting, in New Delhi

to disaster management to enhance the country’s resilience against ex-treme weather events.

During the review, the Home minister directed officials to bring at least 60 lakes under a pro-posed alert network for vulnerable glacial lakes across Jammu and Kashmir, Ladakh, Uttarakhand, Himachal Pradesh, Arunachal Pradesh and Sikkim. The initiative will be implemented

with support from the National Disaster Management Authority (NDMA).

Shah also stressed the need for close coordination between Central and state governments in de-veloping an integrated flood prediction mechanism. He said local response teams in flood-prone regions must remain fully prepared before the monsoon intensifies and

underlined the importance of clear responsibilities at every administrative level.

The Home minister emphasised that disaster preparedness should not remain limited to government agencies alone and called for active public participation in climate resilience efforts. He said communities and local administrations must work together to effectively respond to extreme weather situations.

The meeting also discussed long-term measures to tackle drought and heat wave conditions. Shah underlined the importance of water storage infrastructure, check dams and groundwater recharge projects in drought-prone areas. Officials were informed that CAMPA funds could be utilised more effectively for projects related to land restoration and forest conservation linked to climate resilience.

54.5% VOTER TURNOUT

Haryana local body polls conclude

CHANDIGARH: The local body elections in Haryana, including in the municipal corporations of Ambala, Panchkula and Sonapat, recorded a voter turnout of 54.5 per cent on Sunday, officials said.

Voting began at 8 am and continued till 6 pm amid tight security arrangements. The votes will be counted on May 13, they said.

Polling for the election of mayor and ward councillors in Ambala, Panchkula and Sonapat, president and councillors in the Rewari municipal council, and for presidents and councillors in the municipal committees of Sampla in Rohtak district, Dharuhera in Rewari district, and Uklana in Hisar district took place on Sunday.

In addition, by-elections were held for one ward each in the municipal councils and municipal committees of Tohana, Hajjari, Rajound, Taraori, Kanina and Sadhaura.

Ambala, Panchkula and Sonapat recorded a voter turnout of 54.4 per cent, 52.7 per cent and 47.9 per cent, respectively, according to the State Election Commission (SEC) portal. In Hisar, Rewari and Rohtak, the turnout was 75.7 per cent, 66.1 per cent and 79.2 per cent, respectively.

Out of the total 8.73 lakh eligible voters for the local bodies, 4.75 lakh exercised their franchise, SEC data showed.

A total of 817 polling booths were set up for the elections, in which the ruling BJP and the opposition Congress

are the main contestants.

For the mayor’s post in Ambala, the BJP has fielded Akshita Saini, the Congress nominee is Kulwinder Kaur, while Sonia Rani is contesting as an Independent candidate.

The 20 wards that went to the polls in Ambala comprised 1.98 lakh voters.

In Panchkula, BJP’s Shyamal Bansal and Sudha Bhardwaj of the Congress are contesting for the mayor’s post, along with AAP’s Rajesh Kumar, and Manoj Agarwal of the Indian National Lok Dal (INLD). Polling was held for 20 wards in Panchkula with 2.07 lakh eligible voters.

For the mayor’s post in Sonapat, the BJP has fielded Rajiv Jain, while Kamal Diwan is the Congress nominee. MPOST

Punjab Min Arora sent to 7-day ED custody

MPOST BUREAU

GURUGRAM: A special PMLA court in Gurugram on Sunday remanded Punjab Industries Minister Sanjeev Arora in Enforcement Directorate’s custody for a week in an alleged Rs 100-crore GST fraud-linked money laundering case, observing that the allegations against him are “very serious” and the agency needs to question him to unravel the money trail.

The lawyer for Arora, a senior leader of the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) in Punjab, alleged that a “false and frivolous” case was “cooked up” against the minister and that “no prima facie evidence” was collected by the investigating officer before his arrest.

Arora, 62, was taken into custody by the Enforcement Directorate (ED) on Saturday



evening at his official residence in Chandigarh by the following raids by the agency against him.

The central agency also searched the premises of a Gurugram-based company named Hampton Sky Realty Ltd (HSRL), in which Arora was a director and shareholder. In a statement on Saturday, the company denied any wrongdoing. It said it has faith in the legal process and is fully cooperating with all statutory authorities and will continue to do so.

Arora was brought by agency officials to Gurugram from Chandigarh by road overnight and was produced in the Sessions-cum-special Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA) court of Judge Narendar Sura.

The ED has alleged that its case was against HSRL, linked entities and Arora, who was the “beneficial owner and controller” of the company along with his family members.

The company, during the 2023-24 financial year, sold mobile phones worth Rs 157.12 crore to several local and overseas entities, and, as the CMD of the company, Arora was responsible for the conduct of the business of the company, which undertook alleged illicit transactions, the ED told the court.

It alleged that the company, in connivance with its direc-

tors, employees and linked persons, used “a network of shell entities” to generate “fake” purchase invoices and used them to show “bogus” sales and exports.

The agency claimed the minister was the “key person” involved in the offence of money laundering by bogus billing, fraud, forgery and payment to shell entities.

“Since the allegations against the accused are very serious and the ED is seeking to decode the money trail, role of the accused, vis-a-vis his persons/aides, who facilitated the offence of money laundering, so as to get to know as to how the accused persons were successful in generating proceeds of crime, in opinion of the court, a valid ground exists for the applicant for custodial interrogation of the accused,” Judge Sura said in his order.

AAP terms minister Arora’s arrest ‘attack on Punjab’s future’

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: The Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) has described the arrest of Punjab minister Sanjeev Arora as a “false case” and termed it an attack on Punjab’s trust, development and future.

As the Enforcement Directorate (ED) intensified its action, senior AAP leaders, including national convenor Arvind Kejriwal and Punjab in-charge Manish Sisodia, came out in support of Arora, praising him for refusing to join the BJP despite alleged pressure and highlighting his contribution to Punjab’s industrial and urban development initiatives.

Taking to X, Kejriwal said: “A person’s true character is revealed during difficult times.

Sanjeev Arora chose to go to jail rather than join BJP. Salute to Sanjeev Arora’s courage.”

Manish Sisodia described Arora as an honest and hard-working leader with a clear vision for Punjab’s development. He said Arora’s efforts to attract industrial investment after becoming a minister had earned appreciation from entrepreneurs across the state.

“Ask any entrepreneur in Punjab, and you will hardly find anyone who does not praise Sanjeev Arora’s industrial policy and his way of working,” Sisodia said.

Highlighting Arora’s role in urban infrastructure development, Sisodia said the minister had initiated several projects aimed at improving civic amenities, including street lighting,

organising electricity wire networks and modernising urban infrastructure.

He also noted that Arora had been entrusted with implementing Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann’s ambitious project to underground exposed electricity wires in villages and agricultural areas.

Targeting the BJP over the arrest, Sisodia alleged that action against leaders like Arora was not merely political harassment but an attack on Punjab’s development and public trust.

“When BJP arrests such a hardworking, result-oriented and visionary leader in false cases, it becomes a betrayal of Punjab’s people, Punjab’s development and Punjab’s future,” Sisodia said.

FROM BBM TO THREEMA

How messaging apps fuel J&K terror networks

SRINAGAR: The BlackBerry Messenger (BBM) application has again surfaced on the terror network in Jammu and Kashmir, with the interrogation of a key Lashkar-e-Taiba (LeT) terrorist indicating the use of several applications, including some banned ones, to communicate with other members, officials said on Sunday.

An LeT module, tasked with setting up bases outside Jammu and Kashmir, was busted by the Srinagar police early last month with the arrest of Abdullah alias Abu Hureira, a resident of Kasur in Pakistan’s Punjab, along with another Pakistani terrorist, Mohammed Usman Jatt, and several Overground Workers (OGWs) in Kashmir.

Due to its interstate and global ramifications, the case is now being further investigated by the National Investigation Agency (NIA).

During the investigation, Abu Hureira told investigators that he and his team had been using multiple applications, including BBM, Element, Threema and Dust, alongside main-stream platforms like WhatsApp, Telegram, Skipee and Signal, the officials said.



CLOSER LOOK

» Though digital technologies have been under surveillance since 2016, there has been an increasing concern about cybersecurity environment

» Officials repeatedly flagged the use of messengers such as Threema, a Swiss-based instant messenger that provides total anonymity of communication, making it impossible to trace its users

with the service provider, the officials said.

Though the digital technologies have been under surveillance in Jammu and Kashmir since 2016, there has been an increasing concern about the cybersecurity environment.

Officials have repeatedly flagged the use of highly secure and private instant messengers such as Threema, a Swiss-based instant messenger that provides total anonymity of communication, making it impossible to trace its users since it doesn’t require a phone number or an email.

In May 2023, the Centre banned 14 messaging applications on the recommendation of the Ministry of Home

Affairs. These included Element, the collaboration platform managed by the London-based Element Creations Limited. The app is built on the decentralised Matrix open-standard protocol.

The Element’s removal was specifically attributed to concerns over its use by terrorist mod-ules operating within Jammu and Kashmir to bypass traditional surveillance.

Similarly, apps like Dust (formerly Cyber Dust) have faced increased monitoring due to their emphasis on messages disappearing within 24 hours or immediately after being read. The officials argue that it hampers real-time intelligence gathering.

The petitioner claimed he came to know that ‘even the minimum wages to live with dignity are not given to the priests and temple staff’

public programme and after performing ‘Rudrabhishek’ in the Kashi Vishwanath temple, which is controlled by the state, he came to know that even the minimum wages to live with dignity are not given to the priests and temple staff. “Recently, in Andhra Pradesh and Telangana, priests and temple staff organised a large-scale protest demanding the minimum wages. Priests and temple staff are not getting even the minimum wage prescribed by the State for unskilled and semi-skilled workers. This is a systemic exploitation. State is acting as a model employer through the endowments department, but violating the minimum wages Act and the directive principles of state policy (Article 43),” it said. AGENCY

'SAFFRON SUN RISING FROM BENGALURU'

PM Modi attacks 'parasite' Cong, says it is known for 'betraying' people

OUR CORRESPONDENT

BENGALURU: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday attacked the Congress, accusing it of "failing" to provide good governance due to the internal power struggles in Karnataka, and "betraying" people. It has become a "parasite party" today, he charged.

He said that a "saffron sun" was rising from Bengaluru amid the BJP's expanding political influence across the country, in remarks indicating the party's recent electoral triumphs in West Bengal, Assam Puducherry.

"For the past three years in Karnataka, instead of resolving people's problems, most of the government's time here has been spent resolving internal conflicts. The Congress government remained gripped by uncertainty over leadership and power-sharing arrangements," the PM said addressing a large



Prime Minister Narendra Modi addresses a public meeting, at the Hindustan Aeronautics Limited Airport, in Bengaluru, Sunday PTI

gathering of BJP workers here.

Modi was referring to the ongoing power tussle between Chief Minister Siddaramaiah and his deputy D K Shivakumar for the past six months.

"They cannot decide how long the chief minister will

remain. They cannot decide whether another person will get a chance or not. Everything has been kept hanging," he said.

Modi said the Congress government invariably faced anti-incumbency within months because the party lacked a

Highlights

» For the past three years in Karnataka, instead of resolving people's problems, most of the government's time here has been spent resolving internal conflicts, said PM

» Modi said the Congress government invariably faced anti-incumbency within months because the party lacked a governance agenda

The PM projected the BJP-led NDA as the embodiment of political stability and development, contrasting it with what he described as Congress' "politics of betrayal" and administrative failure in states ruled by the party.

Claiming that the BJP represented stability in an uncertain global environment, Modi said recent election results across states reflected growing public support for the NDA's governance model.

Referring to the NDA retaining power in Puducherry and Assam and forming its maiden government in West Bengal, and the party's sweeping victory in Gujarat local body polls, he said the results indicated a decisive political shift.

"These election results are important for the direction of Indian politics. They reflect the mood of India's youth, women, farmers, poor and middle class," Modi said.

governance agenda. "This is because Congress only knows how to betray people. They are false themselves, and their guarantees are also false. There is no chapter on governance in Congress' book of power," he charged.

K'taka CM chair 'stable', says DK Shivakumar

OUR CORRESPONDENT

RAICHUR: Karnataka Deputy Chief Minister D K Shivakumar on Sunday categorically refuted PM Narendra Modi's remark suggesting that the CM's chair in the state was "wobbling."

Speaking to reporters at Lingasugur in Raichur district, Shivakumar, who is also the Karnataka Pradesh Congress Committee (KPCC) president, said, "No chairs are wobbling in Karnataka. All chairs are stable. I don't know what the PM is referring to."

He was responding to the PM's statement alleging a power struggle within the state government. At the heart of the "power

tussle" within the Karnataka Congress is a reported 2023 understanding between Siddaramaiah and D K Shivakumar.

According to reports, when the Congress high command selected Siddaramaiah as CM, there was an informal understanding that Shivakumar would take over after the government reached its halfway point.

However, the party leadership has not publicly confirmed any such arrangement.

Addressing BJP workers in Bengaluru, Modi on Sunday attacked the Congress, accusing it of "failing to provide good governance due to internal power struggles in Karnataka and of betraying the people."

Strength of democracy lies not in conflict but in institutional balance, mutual respect: Amit Shah

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Union Home minister Amit Shah on Sunday said the strength of democracy lies not in conflict but in institutional balance and mutual respect.

Speaking at the launch of two books authored by Tushar Mehta -- "The Bench, the Bar and the Bizarre" and "The Lawful and the Awful" -- Shah said the author is not only the solicitor general of India and a knowledgeable lawyer, but also his friend.

He said the Constitution and the judiciary have made significant contributions in deepening the roots of India's democracy.

"Since 1947, changes brought by Parliament and the

Vijay's ministers: Combination of youth and experience

Joseph C Vijay took oath as Chief Minister of Tamil Nadu

OUR CORRESPONDENT

CHENNAI: Joseph C Vijay on Sunday took oath as Chief Minister of Tamil Nadu, days after trouncing the DMK in elections.

A 9-member Cabinet, an amalgamation of youth and experience, was sworn-in to assist the CM in administration.

KA Sengottaiyan, from his early days as a leader of Kullapalayam Panchayat in Coimbatore during the 1970s, has carved out a storied 50-year career in Tamil Nadu politics.

His journey from a grassroots party worker to a 10-time legislator stands as a testament to his political endurance.

After MGR's passing, Sengottaiyan emerged as a staunch loyalist of J Jayalalithaa. Throughout AIADMK's various terms in power, he held several key portfolios, most notably serving as the Revenue Minister.

His influence continued in the administration of Edappadi K Palaniswami, where he served as the School Education minister.

Perhaps TVK's most visible face, Aadhav Arjuna is a basketball player and is currently the president of Basketball Federation of India.

A political strategist, he briefly served as Deputy General Secretary for Viduthala Chiruthaigal Katchi (VCK) before parting ways with its chief Thol Thirumavalavan. The Villivakkam MLA-elect is the son-in-law of 'lottery king' Santiago Martin and has been credited for TVK's growth.

N Anand, also known as 'Bussy' Anand, he is recognised as one of the closest political associates of TVK president Vijay.

He played a key organisational role during the formation and growth of the party, helping build its ground network and campaign machinery across Tamil Nadu.



In this combo image, from left, Tamil Nadu CM and TVK chief Vijay, (top row, L-R) party MLAs N Anand, KG Arunraj, Aadhav Arjuna, KA Sengottaiyan, (bottom row, L-R) S Keerthana, P Venkataramanan, Nirmal Kumar, Rajmohan Arumugam, during the swearing-in ceremony of the state government, in Chennai, Sunday PTI

He earned his nickname 'Bussy' after winning the election from the Bussy constituency in Puducherry in 2006 in Puducherry Munnetra Congress.

TVK MLA-elect from the Sivakasi constituency, S Keerthana has been making headlines after the 29-year-old became the first woman NDA to achieve victory in the constituency, putting an end to nearly seven decades of male domination. Over the years, she worked with former CMs Stalin, Mamata Banerjee and incumbent AP CM Chandrababu Naidu.

KG Arunraj, a former Indian Revenue Service officer and a medical doctor by profession.

He was sworn in as a minister in Vijay's Cabinet on Sunday. Kottapalayam Ganesan Arunraj, aged 46 now, gave up his prestigious government job and joined Vijay's Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam.

He served as its general secretary, policy and propaganda, before becoming the minister of the first-ever TVK Cabinet under Vijay.

Arunraj had won from Tiruchengode Assembly constituency in Namakkal district, securing 79,500 votes and trounced his nearest rival SRMT Sekar of the AIADMK by a margin of 28,172 votes.

R Nirmal Kumar, a prom-

inent leader of TVK, who played a crucial role in post-poll negotiations in meeting the left party leaders and securing their support for government formation, Nirmal Kumar had headed the IT and social media unit of the TVK.

He won from the Thirupparankundram Assembly constituency in Madurai.

He was with the BJP initially heading its IT and social media wing and following a brief stint with the AIADMK. Nirmal Kumar joined the TVK in 2025.

A Rajmohan, an actor, stand-up comedian, television anchor, and director who took the oath of office as a minister, was TVK's propaganda secretary. He won from Egmore Assembly constituency.

TVK treasurer P Venkataramanan who assumed charge as minister, is a practicing advocate and he won from Mylapore Assembly constituency.

He is the Brahmin face of TVK. In October 2024, at the first state conference of TVK he had administered the oath to thousands of party activists.

K T Prabhu, another newly inducted minister in Vijay's Cabinet, is a dentist by profession.

He won from Karaikudi constituency in Sivaganga district, defeating NTK founder, and actor-director Seeman.

GREAT NICOBAR DEVELOPMENT PROJECT

Cong urges Environment minister to pause, reflect and revisit venture

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Congress leader Jairam Ramesh wrote to Union Environment minister Bhupendra Yadav on Sunday, claiming that the Great Nicobar Island development project would "destroy" the unique ecosystem there, and urging him to pause, reflect, and revisit the venture in its present design and detail.

In his letter to Yadav, Ramesh said the studies based on which environmental clearance has been granted to the project are "grossly inadequate" and there has been a "mockery of the Environmental Impact Assessment process".

Ramesh highlighted that security experts have written that the country's essential security needs can be met without inflicting such "ecological devastation".

"I wish to reiterate that the Great Nicobar Island's biodiversity is globally unique, and new discoveries are being made from time to time. It is this unique ecosystem that will be destroyed by the Great Nicobar Island development project," the former environment minister said in his letter to Yadav.

Ramesh argued that the compensatory afforestation argument is completely bogus and the minister knows it.

"Security experts have themselves written that the country's essential security needs can be met without inflicting such ecological devastation. I once again urge you to pause, reflect, and revisit the project in its present design and detail," the Congress general secretary in-charge communications asserted.

Ramesh said it is evident that the studies based on which environmental clearance has been granted to the project are not even rapid environmental impact assessments (EIA) and are based on baseline data collection over a few days and weeks at best and are grossly inadequate.

UP Cabinet expansion for 'time pass': Akhilesh

OUR CORRESPONDENT

LUCKNOW: Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav on Sunday took a swipe at the expansion of the Yogi Adityanath government, dismissing it as a mere exercise to "pass the time" and claiming that the chief minister's role under the BJP's rule has been reduced to a "Courier Messenger".

In a post on X, Yadav said, "Samay bitaane ke liye karnaa hai kuch kaam (Need to do something to pass the time)."

"In any case, he has no role to play in the cabinet expansion. A chit will come from over there, and here it will just be read out," he said in the post in Hindi.

Taking a jibe at the chief minister, the SP president said that under the BJP's rule, "CM" has effectively come to mean "Courier Messenger".

"Meanwhile, the public is asking whether you'll watch the film sitting in the front row or from the back? The public's request is that you watch the film carefully...it might just lead to some awakening by understanding the principle of 'Karmaphal-Kansaphal', and perhaps even some positive change," he said in the post.

"We believe that fundamentally, it is not the individual who is evil, but rather their greed is evil. Evil makes a person even worse. Conversely, when an individual sets aside self-interest and embarks upon the path of selfless service, a positive transformation can occur, and they can prove to be a meaningful asset to humanity," Yadav said.

The remarks came after the second expansion of the Yogi Adityanath 2.0 ministry, in which two Cabinet ministers and four ministers of state were inducted into the Uttar Pradesh government, while two ministers of state were elevated to independent charge.

The expansion assumes significance as it comes ahead of the Uttar Pradesh Assembly elections scheduled early next year.

UT with dual power structure 'worst form of govt', says Omar Abdullah

SRINAGAR: Terming the current administrative structure in Jammu and Kashmir the "worst form of government", Chief Minister Omar Abdullah has called for an urgent shift toward full statehood while acknowledging that significant progress has been made in narrowing differences with the Centre over the transaction of business rules.

The chief minister also hit out at vested interests making efforts to create a political wedge between Jammu and Srinagar, saying "they have failed and they will continue to fail", and highlighted the restoration of the traditional biannual shift of the capital known as 'Darbar Move' as a vital bridge in narrowing the emotional divide



J&K Chief Minister Omar Abdullah tries his hand in golf during the inauguration of India Golf Carnival 2026, in Srinagar, Sunday PTI

between the two regions.

Speaking with news agency, Abdullah argued that the logic behind treating a territory with 90 elected legislators on par with smaller regions like Puducherry, which has only 30, remains incomprehensible,

and reiterated his earlier stand that a dual power system where two power structures exist is a "recipe for disaster".

"Can you not see the difference between a tiny one with 30 MLAs and one with 90 MLAs? And you still believe that this current system is beneficial to Jammu and Kashmir after everything that happened last year?" the chief minister asked while referring to the Pahalgam tragedy, pointing out that keeping elected representatives out of the law and order situation was doing no good.

He specifically noted that the size and scale of Jammu and Kashmir demand a governance model where the elected representatives are fully responsible for administration. AGENCIES

How cinema shaping south Indian politics

Blueprint for this crossover was laid in mid-20th century by M Karunanidhi

OUR CORRESPONDENT

CHENNAI: In the rich tapestry of South Indian public life, the transition from the silver screen to the seat of power is a cultural phenomenon. For decades, the boundary between celluloid heroics and legislative leadership has been porous, driven by a unique blend of charismatic stardom and deep-rooted regional identity.

The blueprint for this crossover was laid in the mid-20th century by M Karunanidhi (aka Kalaiginar), M G Ramachandran (MGR) in Tamil Nadu and N T Rama Rao (NTR) in Andhra Pradesh.

Karunanidhi, though a titan of politics, first conquered the world of cinema as a revolutionary screenwriter. Over five decades, he transitioned from being a scriptwriter to a five-time chief minister of Tamil Nadu.

MGR, a superstar who personified the "man of the masses", became chief minister in 1977, cementing a legacy of welfare that lasted decades. Following him, his protégé J Jayalalithaa transitioned from a celebrated actress to a formidable political force known



In this combo image, former Tamil Nadu CMs J Jayalalithaa, M Karunanidhi, former state MLA Vijayakanth. Bottom row, former MoS Chiranjeevi, Andhra Pradesh Deputy Chief Minister Pawan Kalyan and TN Chief Minister S Joseph Vijay PTI

as 'Amma'.

In Andhra Pradesh, NTR achieved the nearly impossible. Often cast as Krishna or Rama on screen, he formed the Telugu Desam Party (TDP) in 1982 and became chief minister within nine months, riding a wave of "Telugu pride".

While the titans dominated the early years, Vijayakanth, affectionately known as "Captain", carved out a unique space in Tamil Nadu. In 2005, he launched the Desiya Murpokku Dravida Kazhagam

(DMDK) as a direct alternative to the established DMK and AIADMK.

In neighbouring Andhra Pradesh, brothers Chiranjeevi and Pawan Kalyan both entered politics, but it was 'Power Star' Kalyan who proved his resilience, suffering electoral setbacks for nearly a decade. It paid off spectacularly in 2024. He ascended to the role of Deputy Chief Minister of Andhra Pradesh.

Meanwhile, 'Megastar' Chiranjeevi, who launched

Key Points

» MGR, a superstar who personified the "man of the masses", became chief minister in 1977

» Other Telugu stars worth mentioning are Nandamuri Balakrishna, a sitting MLA from Hindupur, carries forward his father NTR's legacy with fierce regional loyalty

the Praja Rajyam Party (PRP) in 2008 and managed to capture less than 18 per cent vote share in subsequent elections, eventually gave up on full-time politics.

Other Telugu stars worth mentioning are Nandamuri Balakrishna, a sitting MLA from Hindupur, carries forward his father NTR's legacy with fierce regional loyalty.

Jayaprada served as a two-term MP, famously winning in Uttar Pradesh after a stint in the Rajya Sabha.

Closer Look

» Shah said the Constitution and the judiciary have made significant contributions in deepening the roots of

India's democracy

» People across the country have faith that in case of any injustice, the Constitution is there to protect them, said Shah

assemblies have been accepted without shedding a drop of blood, which shows how deeply rooted democracy is in our country. Courts and the Constitution have a big role to play in achieving this," the home minister said.

He said people across the country have faith that in case of any injustice, the Constitution is there to protect them.

"If there is an assault on rights, the doors of justice are

open, and if anywhere the voice of a weak person is suppressed, the courts will surely hear those voices," he said.

Shah said the faith of the common man, the functioning of the society and the proof of a nation's character lie in a strong justice system, in maintaining trust, in which "we as a society have, by and large, succeeded".

Whatever the loopholes may be, the executive and the judiciary have to plug those through

a concrete, time-bound road-map, he said.

"The beauty of our democracy is that the Constitution has created institutions not for confrontation but to balance one another. The executive takes decisions and the judiciary conducts its judicial review. Our Constitution-makers wrote the Constitution with a spirit of maintaining dialogue, decorum and balance in a very fine manner," the home minister said.

He said in 76 years, hardly any other country has advanced while preserving such values.

"It is a matter of great joy for all of us that here, by and large, all constitutional proprieties have remained intact and we have carried those forward through traditions as well.

Nation Briefs

UP CABINET EXPANSION: BJP WOMAN MLA EXPRESSES UNHAPPINESS

SITAPUR (UP): BJP MLA from Mahmudabad Asha Maurya on Sunday expressed her unhappiness over not being inducted into the Yogi Adityanath ministry. "As a dedicated worker, somewhere deep down, there has certainly been a pain," said Maurya, an OBC face, whose name was being reported by a section of media as among the probable candidates for inclusion in the ministry. In a post on X in Hindi, the MLA wrote, "I express my heartfelt gratitude and thanks to all my journalist colleagues, to everyone who reached out via phone calls from across the nation and the state, and to all the well-wishers, supporters, and affectionate individuals who extended their good wishes and support through social media.

EC HAS BECOME PARTISAN, ALLEGES PRASHANT BHUSHAN AT BENGALURU

BENGALURU: Eminent lawyer Prashant Bhushan on Sunday alleged that the EC had become a completely partisan institution and accused it of using the SIR exercise to "selectively exclude" minorities and weaker sections from electoral rolls. Speaking at a public seminar on 'Delimitation, Women's Reservation Bill and Special Intensive Revision' in Bengaluru, Bhushan said the electoral process, functioning of the Election Commission, delimitation exercise, and implementation of the Women's Reservation Bill posed "serious challenges to India's democracy and federal structure."

COST OF INSULATING INDIA FROM GLOBAL ENERGY SHOCK

Oil cos absorb fuel losses worth over ₹1 lakh crore in 10 weeks

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: About Rs 1,600-1,700 crore per day, over Rs 1 lakh crore in 10 weeks. That's the cost that state-owned oil firms incur for insulating Indian consumers from the global energy shock but ever-widening losses are now raising questions on how long they can continue bearing the cost without financially capitulating.

Since the war broke out in the Middle East 10 weeks ago, state-owned oil marketing companies (OMCs) have ensured uninterrupted supplies of petrol, diesel and cooking gas LPG at rates that are way below cost, unlike many global energy systems that imposed rationing or passed through steep price increases.

This has resulted in the three OMCs - Indian Oil Corporation (IOC), Bharat Petroleum Corporation Ltd (BPCL) and Hindustan Petroleum Corporation Ltd (HPCL) - running record high under-recoveries (the difference between cost and retail selling price), two sources with direct knowledge of the matter said. The combined under-recovery on petrol, diesel and cooking gas LPG is Rs 1,600 crore to Rs 1,700 crore daily, they said, adding total under-recovery for the 10 weeks is now well over Rs 1 lakh crore.

Despite a 50 per cent surge



Since the war broke out in the Middle East 10 weeks ago, state-owned oil marketing companies have ensured uninterrupted supplies of petrol, diesel and cooking gas LPG at rates that are way below cost

in input crude oil prices, petrol and diesel continue to be priced at a two-year-old rate of Rs 94.77 a litre and Rs 87.67 per litre respectively. Domestic cooking gas LPG prices were raised in March by Rs 60 per cylinder, but they are still way lower than the actual cost.

The revenues that OMCs earn from selling fuel are the only source that is used by them to buy crude oil (raw material), build infrastructure to process it into fuel and lay a network to take the product to consumers.

For 10 weeks, the OMCs

have managed to insulate the Indian market but now the cost is visible, sources said adding they may have to borrow more to meet the working capital requirement (buying of crude oil).

"If elevated crude prices persist for an extended period, OMCs may require higher working capital borrowings and calibrated reprioritisation of some capex timelines," a source said. "However, strategic investments in refining expansion, energy security infrastructure, ethanol blending, biofuels,

Highlights

- » This has resulted in the three OMCs - IOC, BPCL and HPCL - running record high under-recoveries
- » Despite a 50% surge in input crude oil prices, petrol and diesel continue to be priced at a two-year-old rate of Rs 94.77/litre and Rs 87.67/litre respectively
- » Domestic cooking gas LPG prices were raised in March by Rs 60 per cylinder, but they are still way lower than the actual cost

and transition fuels continue to remain national priorities and are expected to proceed with Government support.

Another source said the OMCs are operating under significant financial pressure. "Financially strong OMCs are critical for India's energy security, supply continuity, infrastructure expansion, and economic stability. Sustained stress on OMC balance sheets could affect future investments in refining, pipelines, strategic reserves, clean fuels, and energy transition initiatives."

To raise petrol and diesel prices is now a political call that the government will have to take, a separate source said. "There is no doubt that a fuel price hike has become inevitable, but the timing and quantum of increase have to be decided by the government..

While countries from Japan to the UK have raised petrol and diesel prices by up to 30 per cent since the start of the West Asia conflict, fuel prices in India continue at two-year-old levels.

This despite the war disrupting India's import of 40 per cent of crude oil (raw material for making petrol and diesel), 90 per cent cooking gas LPG and 65 per cent natural gas (used to generate electricity, make fertiliser, turned into CNG and piped to household kitchens for cooking).

While the three OMCs have worked overtime to keep the supply lines running even when demand spiked due to panic buying, the government intervention included excise duty reductions to absorb part of the fuel cost burden. The special additional excise duty on petrol was cut to Rs 3 per litre from Rs 13, while excise duty on diesel was reduced to zero from Rs 10 per litre.

The government has taken a hit of Rs 14,000 crore a month in cutting the excise duty, sources said.

Adani to set up cement unit in MP with ₹1,060 cr investment

MPOST BUREAU

GUNA: Adani Cement laid the foundation stone for a new cement grinding unit in Guna, Madhya Pradesh on Sunday, with an investment of over Rs 1,060 crore. The foundation stone for the Ambuja Cements plant was laid by Madhya Pradesh Chief Minister Mohan Yadav and Union Minister of Communications Jyotiraditya Scindia.

Addressing the event, Pranav Adani, Managing Director of Adani Enterprises said the project would give a new direction to the development of Madhya Pradesh. He said the state had gained fresh momentum under the leadership of Chief Minister Mohan Yadav, with the government focusing on infrastructure, industry and employment.

Pranav Adani said Madhya Pradesh's GDP is projected to exceed Rs 15 lakh crore in 2025, which reflects the state's strong growth trajectory. He added that improvements in logistics, industrial infrastructure and transportation under Prime Minister Narendra Modi's PM Gati-Shakti Vision have created a robust investment environment in the state.

Speaking about the group's broader investment plans, he said Gautam Adani had pledged investments worth Rs 110,000 crore in Madhya Pradesh during the Global Investors Summit held in Bhopal last year. The investments are planned across sectors such as Hydro Pumped Storage, Cement, Mining, Smart



Pranav Adani, Managing Director of Adani Enterprises

On employment generation, Pranav Adani said the initiative would create new job opportunities for 120,000 people by 2030

Meters and Thermal Energy.

On employment generation, Pranav Adani said the initiative would create new job opportunities for 120,000 people by 2030. He said the Guna cement grinding project would be developed in two phases with an annual capacity of 40 lakh metric tonnes, while Phase One is targeted for commissioning by 2028.

He added that the project would be executed with a focus on speed, quality and environmental sustainability.

According to him, the investment of over Rs 1,060 crore is the largest investment in Guna to date. The project is expected to generate direct and

Key Points

- » Pranav Adani, Managing Director of Adani Enterprises said the project would give a new direction to the development of Madhya Pradesh
- » He said the Guna cement grinding project would be developed in two phases with an annual capacity of 40 lakh metric tonnes
- » The project is expected to generate direct and indirect employment for around 1,500 people and contribute over Rs 6,000 crore to the state treasury in the future

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Pranav Adani said the plant would also create opportunities for small businesses, transportation services, local supply chains and other support sectors in the surrounding region.

He described the project as not just an investment in a cement plant, but also an investment in the people and youth of Madhya Pradesh and in the state's future progress. He added that the Adani Group would continue to partner in the development of Madhya Pradesh and contribute to India's nation-building efforts.

Aramco Q1 profit jumps 25% to \$32.5 bn

RIYADH: Aramco, the world's largest oil company, reported Sunday that its first quarter profits jumped 25 per cent over last year, as it increased exports by using a pipeline that avoids shipping through the Strait of Hormuz, which has been disrupted by the Iran war.

Formally known as the Saudi Arabian Oil Co, Aramco reported a profit of \$32.5 billion for the quarter ending March 31, 2026. The company had reported a 12 per cent decline in annual profits in 2025.

"Aramco's first-quarter performance reflects strong resilience and operational flexibility in a complex geopolitical environment," Aramco President and CEO Amin H Nasser said in a statement, adding that the company's East-West Pipeline, which runs across Saudi Arabia from its Eastern oil fields to the Red Sea, is now operating at its maximum capacity of 7 million barrels of oil per day. Nasser said the pipeline is "helping to mitigate the impact of a global energy shock and providing relief to customers."

However, it cannot replace the capacity lost to the shipping disruption in the Strait of Hormuz. Before the war, 20 per cent of the world's traded oil typically flowed through the strait every day, as well as large supplies of natural gas, fertiliser and other petroleum products.

'AI has terminated over 1K staff in last 3 yrs for ethical breaches'

MUMBAI: Air India has terminated more than 1,000 staff in the last three years for ethical breaches, including those for misusing the employee leisure travel system, according to the airline's chief Campbell Wilson.

Flagging that hundreds of employees are terminated every year due to non-compliance, Wilson has also emphasised that the staff need to act in the right way even when others are not looking.

As Air India implements cost-saving measures amid significant financial headwinds, Wilson made the remarks during the town hall meeting with the staff on Friday, according to sources.

Tata Group-owned Air India has around 24,000 employees now.

The airline's CEO and



MD said that over the past three years, "we have terminated more than 1,000 people for ethical breach" such as smuggling things off the plane and allowing excess baggage onto the aircraft without being charged.

He also mentioned hundreds of staff who had misused the Employee Leisure Travel (ELT) system and added that such things should not happen.

In March, sources told PTI that the airline has detected

large-scale discrepancies in the utilisation of its leisure travel policy, involving more than 4,000 employees and has initiated corrective actions, including imposing penalties on the erring staff.

Air India has resorted to cost-cutting measures, including holding back annual increments for staff and asking them to cut discretionary spending as well as non-critical expenditures, warning of "tough times". On Friday, Wilson told the staff it is going to be a "very, very difficult year" if things don't improve on the Middle East front.

The Air India Group -- Air India and Air India Express -- is projected to have incurred more than Rs 22,000 crore loss in the financial year ended March 2026.

Oil prices likely to stay higher for longer due to Middle East crisis: ADB Chief Economist

NEW DELHI: Crude oil prices are likely to stay higher for longer due to the disruption caused by the longer-than-expected Middle East crisis, ADB Chief Economist Albert Park has said.

"With a higher oil price expectation, we actually have it as \$96 per barrel as average for 2026 as per the new reference scenario. It should stay elevated at \$80 per barrel in 2027. So, our idea is that the oil prices are likely to stay higher for longer," Park said. Future prices are showing higher prices farther out into next year than they did before, he said.

However, he said, "We have also seen always a kind of a premium of the spot market prices and the nearby futures market because there is such a shortage currently."

Speaking about the impact



of the ongoing Middle East crisis on India, Park said it is going to shave off 0.6 per cent from the country's GDP growth, bringing it to 6.3 per cent, and also stoke inflation significantly in the current financial year.

The Asian Development Bank (ADB) in April projected India's GDP growth to remain "robust" at 6.9 per cent in the current fiscal, and rise to 7.3 per cent in the next fiscal, driven by strong domestic demand.

With regard to inflation, ADB had projected 4.5 per cent for the current fiscal.

CMS bags ₹400 crore contract to manage 6K HDFC Bank ATMs

MUMBAI: CMS Info Systems on Sunday announced that it has bagged a Rs 400 crore order from HDFC Bank to manage 6,000 ATMs of the largest private-sector lender for five years.

This is an integrated ATM managed services outsourcing mandate under which CMS will also offer solutions like currency forecasting and logistics, and an AI solution, an official statement said.

The deal will help the company increase revenues from private sector banks to 30 per cent by the end of FY27 from the current 25 per cent, said its



Chief Business Officer, Anush Raghavan.

He added that the company expanded its partnership with ICICI Bank in the last fiscal and recently bagged a Rs 1,000-crore contract from the largest lender, SBI. HDFC Bank had a network of over 21,000 ATMs as of March 2026.

Pvt capital expenditure rises 67% to ₹7.7 lakh cr in Sept 2025: CII

NEW DELHI: India's private sector capital expenditure rose 67 per cent year-on-year to Rs 7.7 lakh crore in September 2025 from Rs 4.6 lakh crore a year earlier, Confederation of Indian Industry (CII) said on Sunday, describing it as strong evidence of a broad-based revival in the investment cycle.

CII also unveiled a five-point industry action agenda amid the ongoing West Asia crisis, including a phased roll-back of the Rs 10 per litre cut in central excise duty on petrol and diesel over six to nine months as crude prices stabilise.

The industry body's analysis of nearly 1,200 companies from the CMIE Prowess data-

base showed manufacturing accounted for Rs 3.8 lakh crore, nearly half of total private capex, led by metals, automobiles and chemicals. Services contributed Rs 3.1 lakh crore, driven by trading, communications and IT/ITes.

The agenda also proposed a voluntary 45-day MSME payment guarantee by larger corporates through wider use of the TReDS platform and supply-chain finance to ease working capital pressure on small businesses. Other measures include front-loading private capex, voluntary price restraint, higher internship intake, diversified sourcing, strategic inventory buffers and deeper domestic

value addition in components, specialty chemicals and capital goods.

Supporting indicators reflected improving investment sentiment. Capacity utilisation of manufacturing firms rose to 75.6 per cent in Q3FY26 from 74.3 per cent in the previous quarter, while new order books grew 10.3 per cent year-on-year. Bank credit growth averaged nearly 14 per cent in the second half of FY26 compared with around 10 per cent in the first half.

CII Director General Chandrajit Banerjee urged industry to support the economy during the ongoing period of global uncertainty.

RBI, ECB sign MoU to deepen cooperation

MUMBAI: Reserve Bank of India and European Central Bank on Sunday signed a memorandum of understanding (MoU) on mutual cooperation, a statement said.

Sanjay Malhotra, Governor of the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) and Christine Lagarde, President of the European Central Bank (ECB), signed the MoU on cooperation in the field of central banking.

"The MoU, which updates the previous MoU of 2015, provides a framework for a regular exchange of information, policy dialogue and technical cooperation



RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra with ECB President Christine Lagarde after signing of MoU

between the two institutions in areas of mutual interest in the field of central banking," RBI said in the statement.

The signing took place on the margins of the Bank for International Settlements (BIS) meetings in Basel. MPOST

NTPC prepares first feasibility study for nuclear project, to apply for approval soon

The nod will pave way for NTPC to start work on its 1st standalone nuclear project in India as it aims to achieve at least 2 GW of nuclear capacity by 2032

NEW DELHI: Power giant NTPC will soon submit its first feasibility study for a nuclear project with the Department of Atomic Energy (DAE) and seek its nod to go ahead with the plan, sources said. The approval will pave the way for NTPC to start work on its first standalone nuclear project in India as the PSU is keen to achieve at least 2 GW of nuclear capacity by 2032.

Further, the company is in process of conducting feasibility studies in two more states and in the latest development has received a go-ahead from the Bihar government to conduct a feasibility study for a nuclear

project in the state's Banka district, they said.

As part of its energy diversification strategy, NTPC is looking to set up 30 GW of nuclear projects in at least 14 states with investments worth lakhs of crores to contribute to the government's ambitious 100 GW nuclear capacity target by 2047.

NTPC has completed feasibility study in one of the states, while it is in the process of undertaking feasibility studies in another two states, two sources aware of the development said. "The company will be very soon submitting the



completed feasibility study for the nuclear project in the state," one of the sources said. He did not divulge any site-related information due to the sensitivity of the subject. As per the process, the Standing Site Selection Committee of the DAE reviews

CLOSER LOOK

- » As part of its diversification strategy, NTPC is looking to set up 30 GW of nuclear projects in at least 14 states
- » 'A feasibility study comprises rough estimates related to investments, land and water, among other requirements'
- » NTPC is exploring states such as Gujarat, Andhra Pradesh, Maharashtra, Madhya Pradesh among others

any such proposals, and if found technically feasible puts it to the Atomic Energy Commission (AEC) for further process.

Another source said NTPC is nearing completion of feasibility studies for nuclear projects in two more states, and recently

Energy Department of the Bihar government has given its support to the company to conduct a feasibility study for a project in the Banka district.

Sources further said that a feasibility study comprises rough estimates related to

investments, land and water, among other requirements.

"On an average, NTPC is looking to set up at least two units of 700 megawatt each in the states being explored for nuclear projects," a source said.

Industry estimates suggest that to set up a nuclear power capacity of 1 gigawatt, typically an investment of Rs 15,000-20,000 crore is required and the timeframe could be at least three years from concept to commissioning. Five litres water is needed to produce 1 unit of nuclear power. Land requirement depends on the size of the project with 1 square kilometre

exclusion zone.

Of various other inputs, continuous water supply is a key requirement for a nuclear project. NTPC is exploring states such as Gujarat, Andhra Pradesh, Maharashtra, Madhya Pradesh among others for its nuclear ambitions.

Established in 1975 as a thermal power generator, NTPC Ltd has steadily expanded and diversified into new energy sources. According to the NTPC website, the company currently has an installed capacity of 89,805.30 MW at group-level, spanning coal, gas/liquid fuel, hydro and solar power.

In the nuclear space, the company is presently setting up a nuclear project in a joint venture (JV) with Nuclear Power Corporation of India Ltd (NPCIL) in Rajasthan at an investment of about Rs 42,000 crore. While NTPC has a 49 per cent stake in ASHVINI (Anushakti Vidyut Nigam Ltd), NPCIL has the majority shareholding of 51 per cent.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi laid the foundation stone of the 4x700 MW Mahi Banswara Rajasthan Atomic Power Project (MBRAPP) being set up by ASHVINI at Banswara in September last year.

The actress highlighted the deep-rooted patriarchy that continues to influence filmmaking



KRITI SANON ON PATRIARCHY IN BOLLYWOOD

‘Actors take the bigger cut’

Pay parity has long been a topic of discussion in the Indian film industry. Over the years, several actors, including Anushka Sharma, Taapsee Pannu, Deepika Padukone and Kareena Kapoor, have voiced concerns about gender-based pay gaps.

Kriti Sanon added her voice to the conversation, highlighting the deep-rooted patriarchy that continues to influence filmmaking.

In a conversation with ‘GQ’, Kriti opened up about the financial inequalities female actors face. “There’s been some struggle around money. When the producers have to cut corners, they often negotiate down the female lead’s fee, even though a large chunk of the budget goes to the male actor.”

She added, “Patriarchy is still deeply ingrained in the industry and we have to keep shaking things up to move towards equality. It shows up in the smallest ways, too, for instance, there’s often a tendency on a film set to check if the female actor is ready first, so the male actor doesn’t have to wait. It’s subconscious, but it needs to change.”

Sanon also shared a personal experience, “I’ve always tried to stand up for myself, but early in my career, it was difficult to voice everything. I remember small things, like a male co-star, who wasn’t a senior, getting a better car. Of course, it wasn’t about the



car, but about being respected equally. Most producers and directors today are progressive, but these biases still exist.”

When asked if this motivated her to turn producer with last year’s film ‘Do Patti’, she explained, “As an actor, I’m drawn towards strong-minded, inspiring female characters and that naturally reflects in the projects I produce as well. It doesn’t mean I wouldn’t do male-centric films; I’m open to that. But I want to create more opportunities for women because there are still very few meaty, well-written scripts for us. Women often play smaller roles in male-led films, but very few top male actors play supporting characters in stories headlined by women. I hope to change that mindset.”

AGENCIES

‘We have to keep shaking things up to move towards equality,’ says Kriti

Priyanka Chopra Jonas felicitated with Global Vanguard Honour

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Hollywood superstar and global icon Priyanka Chopra Jonas was honoured with the prestigious Global Vanguard Honour at the Gold House Gold Gala 2026, a recognition reserved for influential figures shaping cross-cultural narratives and global representation.

One of the most powerful cultural voices on the international stage today, Priyanka has spent over two decades breaking barriers for South Asian talent globally. From becoming the first South Asian actor to headline an American network drama with ‘Quantico’ to fronting solo international posters for global

She has spent over two decades breaking barriers for South Asian talent globally

franchises like ‘Citadel’, she has consistently redefined representation for Indian artists in mainstream global entertainment.

Her remarkable 25-year journey has seamlessly bridged Hindi cinema and Hollywood, establishing her as one of the rare Indian stars to build sustained influence across entertainment, fashion, business and advocacy on a truly global scale. Through her production company, ‘Pur-

ple Pebble Pictures’, Priyanka has also championed emerging and underrepresented voices in storytelling, an impact that has earned her recognition on platforms including ‘TIME 100’ and Forbes’ ‘Most Powerful Women’.

Held at The Music Centre in downtown Los Angeles under the theme ‘A New Gold World’, the Gold Gala 2026 celebrated cultural influence, leadership and shared progress. Priyanka joined fellow honourees, including Charles Melton, Jet Li, Simu Liu, EJAE and more.

With this latest milestone, Priyanka Chopra Jonas continues to stand as one of the defining global faces of representation, influence and cultural impact today.



Disha Patani to make Hollywood debut with ‘THE PORTAL OF FORCE’

NEW DELHI: Bollywood actress Disha Patani is all set to take on the role of Jessica in the first film of ‘Statiguards vs Holi-guards Saga’, titled ‘The Portal of Force’ and said the project served the scope to explore the craft massively.

Described as a ‘supernatural action-thriller’, the film is directed by Kevin Spacey and marks his return to direction after over 20 years. It is a part of the ‘Statiguards vs Holi-guards Saga’, which is centred on a secret war between two ancient, opposing factions. The film features Patani alongside Spacey, Tyrese Gibson and Dolph Lundgren.

Patani said the experience of working on an international film is both ‘thrilling and terrifying’. “I’ve waited with bated breath for the trailer of this very special project. Stepping into

my first international outing was both thrilling and terrifying, but the scope to explore the craft was massive. Working with an experienced, diverse cast was an education in itself,” she said.

“You realise that storytelling transcends language and geography; honesty on screen is universal. I’ve always loved action and to bring what I’ve learned on the home turf to a global platform feels incredibly empowering,” she added.

The trailer introduces Patani’s character as the daughter of rival leaders on both sides - a living bridge between warring worlds - and the ultimate decider in a battle that could determine how this war ends and humanity’s fate along with it.

PTI



Nora Fatehi to perform at opening ceremony of FIFA World Cup



NEW DELHI: Nora Fatehi is set to perform at the opening ceremony of the FIFA World Cup 2026, which will take place in Canada on June 12.

The announcement was made by the official ‘Instagram’ handle of the FIFA World Cup on Saturday. It featured the names of the performers, which included Fatehi. She will perform alongside Michael Buble, Alanis Morissette, Alessia Cara, Elyanna, Jessie Reyez, Sanjoy, Vegedream and William Prince. It will take place at BMO Field in Toronto.

Fatehi also shared a poster on her ‘Instagram’ as she announced the news and said she is honoured. “It’s OFFICIAL! I am honoured to announce once AGAIN that I will be part of the first largest FIFA World Cup in history! WE DEFINITELY LOCKED IN LET’S GO @fifaworldcup,” she wrote.

The actress has previously performed at the closing ceremony of the 2022 FIFA World Cup in Qatar.

PTI

When Shiva arrives in the Alps

This is the world Sohini Roychowdhury has been building across schools and universities in Austria and Germany with the ‘India Quartet’

OUR CORRESPONDENT

On a grey morning in the Austrian Alps, a classroom full of children raised their hands into lotus mudras. Outside, the mountains remained still and snow lined up. Inside, Shiva was dancing.

Not in the grand theatrical sense, not beneath temple lamps or carved stone ceilings, but in a school gymnasium where a group of students - many encountering Indian classical art for the first time - learnt how meaning can travel through the body. A lifted wrist. A turning gaze. The quiet geometry of fingers opening into a flower.

This is the world Sohini Roychowdhury has been building across schools and universities in Austria and Germany with the ‘India Quartet’: part performance, part cultural exchange and part philosophical encounter. Over the course of a tour reaching nearly 20 institutions, from young children to university students, the troupe moves through alpine towns carrying Bharatanatyam, live Indian classical music, storytelling and the meditative vibration of ‘Om’ into spaces more accustomed to Mozart than ‘mudras’. But the project resists the stiffness of a formal ‘cultural program’. What unfolds instead feels intimate,



improvisational and almost unexpectedly contemporary.

Roychowdhury, a Bharatanatyam dancer with a sharply expressive stage presence, treats mythology less as distant heritage and more as living psychology. Her Shiva is not merely a divine spectacle - he is rhythm, destruction, balance, stillness, masculinity and tenderness held together in one body. She paused frequently to involve the students directly, asking them to repeat gestures, mirror emotions or respond

instinctively to movement. The result is not passive observation but participation.

At one school, children began instinctively echoing her movements before being asked to. At another, teenagers who arrived guarded and amused, slowly leaned forward, trying to decode the emotional language hidden

Roychowdhury, a Bharatanatyam dancer with a sharply expressive stage presence, treats mythology less as distant heritage and more as living psychology



inside the dance.

The music surrounding her operates almost cinematically. Musician Indro Roychowdhury introduces ‘ragas’ not through academic explanation but through feeling, describing them as emotional atmospheres tied to time, season and interior states. A melody becomes dawn. Another becomes longing. Students begin to understand that Indian classical music is not simply performed; it is inhabited.

As Sohini dances in response, the relationship between movement and sound becomes startlingly clear, even to audiences with no prior exposure to either form.

Johannes Blaas, respected professor, musician and the ensemble’s tanpura player, provided the evening’s quiet philosophical centre. His observations on listening, resonance and musical

continuity bridge European and Indian traditions with unusual ease. Meanwhile, Sanjib Pal’s tabla rhythms pulsed beneath the performances with understated precision, occasionally evoking the primal beat of Shiva’s ‘damru’.

What lingers after these workshops is not only the performance itself, but the atmosphere they leave behind: children speaking Sanskrit syllables with surprising confidence, students discussing mythology alongside rhythm cycles and classrooms temporarily transformed into shared spaces of imagination.

In an era where ‘global culture’ is often flattened into algorithmic sameness, the India Quartet’s work feels refreshingly tactile. Nothing is simplified for easy consumption. Instead, complexity is offered generously and audiences are trusted to meet it with curiosity.

Somewhere between the Alps and the ancient stories of Shiva, a different kind of exchange is taking place - not just cultural export, but mutual recognition. The discovery that rhythm, gesture, silence and wonder require very little translation at all.